A LIVING PRACTICE

We approach artistic research not as a linear path towards a conclusion, but as an event in itself—a living practice. To us, research is a radical act, a way of thinking not only about materials, but with them, and through them.

With our tools, we retool what it means to inquire, to know, and to share that knowledge. Our work spans theoretical reflection, archival research, and hands-on making, slow-making, re-making, queer-making, faith-making, and story-making—across time, bodies, and disciplines. We embrace the unruly, the rigorous, the unfinished. This publication invites you into a space where process holds as much weight as outcome, and where making is a mode of research, relation, and resistance.

The publication traces our research process during our time at Konstfack and brings together our individual explorations, articulated through personal formats and methods. It encompasses encounters with faith and ritual that open new ways of relating to the textiles around us, an intimate portrait of the forest industry in Värmland, a road trip to a queer bog in Tornedalen, and a stitch-by-stitch unveiling of the darker chapters of US history through a quilt. It also documents the discovery of one's creative practice through the abandoned remnants of other artists, the love of paper and the care embedded in wrapping and unwrapping, and reflections on what the verb "to create" means—figuratively, literally, and materially.

AUTHORS:

VICTORIA CLEVERBY, TOVA FRANSSON, HEATHER JONES, EVER LAVÉN, LISA RYDELL, LISA SANDER, IDA ISAK WESTERBERG

ORSUS / VICTORIA CLEVERBY
TIMBER SEMIOTICS / TOVA FRANSSON
AS AMERICAN AS____ / HEATHER JONES
WARSHIP / EVER LAVÉN
UNBOXING FIBERS / LISA RYDELL
THREADS OF THOUGHT AND MAKING / LISA SANDER
SOMPASENVUOMA QUEERNESS / IDA ISAK WESTERBERG

A Living Practice

Projects realized during the course Research Lab CRAFT! 2024–2025
at Konstfack University of Arts, Crafts and Design, Stockholm, Sweden.

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Heather Jones, Ever Lavén, Lisa Rydell,
Lisa Sander, Ida Isak Westerberg

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PROLOGUE

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FOREWORD

MAJA GUNN

MAJA GUNN
FOREWORD

With this publication, we invite you as readers to gain insight into a diverse set of artistic research practices and their processes. The projects has been developed within the one-year course Research Lab CRAFT! taught at the Department of Crafts, Konstfack, University of Arts, Crafts and Design, Stockholm, Sweden. The course is designed for professional artists with an interest in artistic research, under the supervision of Professor Maja Gunn. Throughout the year, the artists have been exposed to a variety of existing research projects, offering multiple points of entry into the discourse of artistic research their own projects may resonate with, respond to, or diverge from. Thereby contributing to the continuous reshaping of the field.

Today, artistic research constitutes a broad and heterogeneous field, encompassing a multiplicity of disciplines, materials, methodologies, and theoretical frameworks. It enables deepened artistic engagement, the emergence of new questions, and the formulation of alternative methods and practices. Nevertheless, the scope of what can be conveyed within the limits of publication is inherently restricted. Beyond the texts and images presented here lies a body of research enacted through and within artistic practice—research that often exceeds the capacities of language or photographic documentation. Throughout the course, students have engaged extensively in studio-based work, participated actively in professional artistic contexts, facilitated workshops across educational programmes, and realised exhibitions. Artistic research, as demonstrated in these projects, is both undertaken and communicated through a diversity of formats, practices, and discourses.

The artistic research projects presented in this publication reflect a sustained engagement with themes such as materiality, methodology, history, politics, ecology, rituals, language, and creative writing. While grounded in the individual interests of the participating artists, the works also function as critical reflections of contemporary socio-cultural conditions.

Concerns regarding the environment and diversity are articulated, for instance, in Tova Fransson's investigation of indicator species and in Ida Isak Westerberg's exploration of the mire in

Övertorneå as a queer space. The situated nature of the research—its embeddedness in specific geographies—plays a crucial role, as do methodological choices, theoretical frameworks, material, and technical processes of artistic articulation. Fragility—whether manifested in endangered vegetation or in textiles at risk of disintegration—emerges as a conceptual thread, serving as a reminder of impermanence, ecological values, and the necessity of secure spaces for growth, agency, and expression.

Lisa Rydell's project engages with notions of unboxing and the desire embedded in that which is inaccessible or concealed. Drawing from her extensive experience in paper and graphic design, she approaches craft and textile through practices such as shifu, a traditional Japanese technique. The project traces a material transition and a movement toward the unknown, facilitated through the investigation of craft methodologies. Ever Lavén's work operates poetically across material, memory, and ritual. Here, textile becomes a site for examining temporality, spiritual practices, and rituals. The project investigates the interplay and transformation of bodies, beliefs, histories, and materials, positioning textile not merely as a medium but as an epistemological space.

Artistic method functions as a unifying element across the projects, particularly evident in Lisa Sander's research, which approaches methodology through the lens of rejected artworks by other artists. The encounter—with vulnerability, with incompletion—serves as a point of departure for a search for both method and individual artistic expression. Victoria Cleverby's work interrogates the relationship between weaving and language, drawing specifically on the Hebrew word bara (ברא), examined through the dual lenses of creation and separation. Language is approached performatively, through woven works in which cutting emerges as both method and metaphor—simultaneously poetic and fragile. The accompanying text navigates between the academic and the personal, the quotidian and the familiar. Text likewise plays a critical role in Heather Jones's project, which combines archival research with creative writing through the methodological framework of critical fabulation. By engaging with the quilt as both object and archive, the project positions a

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FOREWORD

family history in dialogue with broader narratives of American politics, identity, and historiography. Artistic research, in this context, affords the possibility of integrating fiction and reality, and of embracing the speculative and the imaginative as legitimate components of scholarly inquiry.

Artistic researchers frequently operate both within and beyond the academy. This dual positioning is also reflected in the contributions to this publication. The capacity to move between academic, artistic, and public spheres offers the potential for wide-ranging impact. Within the course, research has not been confined to textual output alone; instead, it has been articulated through artistic practice itself. Exhibitions, workshops, and performative formats have served not only as means of dissemination but also as methods of inquiry and production.

Notably, during the period in which the course has run, a broader public debate concerning the legitimacy, purpose, and epistemological foundations of artistic research has emerged in Swedish media. These discussions have also found their way into the seminar room, where we have critically examined the challenges and complexities faced by researchers in this field—including the resistance that can arise when new or unfamiliar forms of knowledge production are introduced into the academic landscape.

In this context Research Lab CRAFT! serves as a vital platform for professional artists to engage with research in a structured yet experimental way. Some participants use the course to deepen their artistic practice; others use it as a springboard to formulate research proposals or pursue doctoral studies. The projects developed within the course reflect a high level of critical engagement, methodological sensitivity, and artistic integrity.

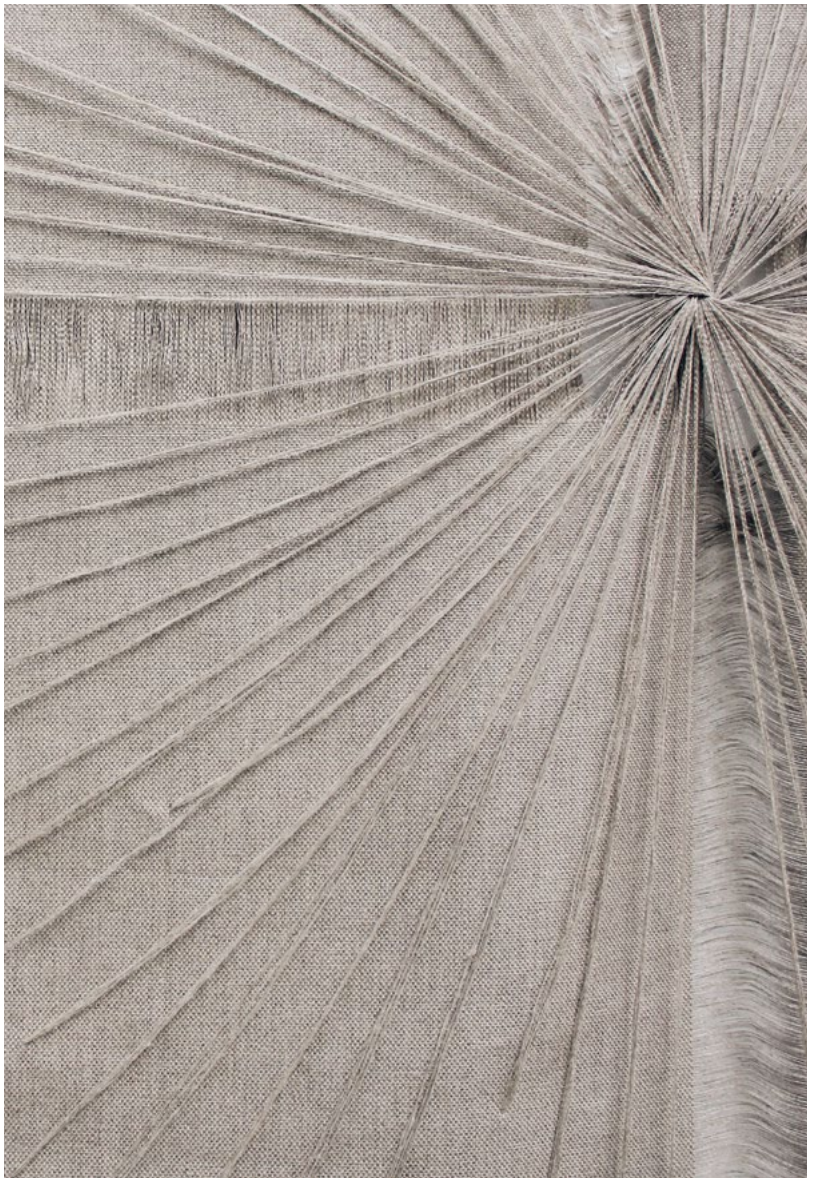
It is with pride that I, as Professor and coordinator of this course, introduce this publication and warmly invite you, as readers, to explore the contributions within.

ORSUS

A SHORT STORY ON WEAVINGS, LANGUAGE, AND DISTANCE

VICTORIA CLEVERBY

VICTORIA CLEVERBY ORSUS A SHORT STORY ON WEAVINGS, LANGUAGE, AND DISTANCE



All images are authours own. © Victoria Cleverby

She was beginning to get annoyed. Whenever she asked her partner about their relationship status, he said they were soulmates. She had repeatedly pointed out the absurdity of his answer, as she knew he disagreed with the concept of a soul. He had no patience with such discussions and said, of course, there is no such thing as a soul; there is only a body. She then reminded him that his argument wasn't obvious. Especially not historically. She told him about how in ancient Egypt there had been a belief that an individual was made up of 9 physical and spiritual elements. Like Khat the physical body, Ka the life force that gives energy to the physical body, and Ba the aspect that makes up the personality. He just laughed, told her there was no Ba to be found anywhere in him.

But she knew there was Ba in his life. It stared at her every morning in the bathroom – his set of creme, toners, and moisturizers. BHA was the acronym of Beta Hydroxy Acid. And although she knew it was pronounced B-H-A, she always read it as Ba. One past morning when she'd been combing her hair and he was washing his face, she'd explained to him the linguistic concept of lexical differentiation, which suggests that when a language has multiple words for a single concept, it reflects the culture's focus on its nuances. When the ancient Egyptian language had many words for the aspects that make up an individual, modern Swedish has very few. She thought, but was only guessing, that the ancient Egyptians didn't have as many words for acids to make your face glow, as the containers and boxes on her partner's shelf had. She, on the other hand, was more interested in the Ba as in the aspect that makes up the personality, rather than the Ba of Beta Hydroxy Acid. She had just come out of a period of about a year when she had been utterly obsessed with ancient Egyptian culture. Now she had moved on, or at least moved forward in history. At the moment, her thoughts centered around the Adamic language.

Some Jewish and Christian traditions speak of an Adamic language present at the beginning, where words and things were fully united. Like in Genesis when God creates light. God speaks, and in the exact moment the word "light" is spoken, light is created. What caught her interest was how a creation story like this makes

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the word the origin of the Universe. She also saw a description of a state in time where the correspondence between words and objects was absolute. The Adamic language was said to convey knowledge in such a direct way that its speakers directly knew and understood everything. It was unclear if it had ever existed, but the myth said the Adamic language was lost when humanity was expelled from the Garden of Eden.

She made her living as a textile artist. She recently emerged from a project on how various cultures have used the weave as a metaphor for the universe. Like the Navajo culture, where Spider Woman is described as weaving both the world and its inhabitants, or the Hindu culture, which explains how Brahma is the superior God from which all worlds are woven as warp and weft. Even Einstein, through his general theory of relativity, likened space-time to a weave forming the foundation of the Universe. Currently, she was occupied by an artistic research project. Her topic was language, and her research question pondered the relationship between creation and separation, and what she could learn about it if she explored it through textiles.

Her interest regarding the relationship between separation and creation had begun a few months earlier when she'd read an article about biblical interpretation. The article described how a minority of biblical scholars for almost a decade had been questioning the translation of the first line of Genesis that in Hebrew read: "בראשית ברא אלהים את השמים ואת הארץ" (bereshit bara Elohim et hashamayim ve et ha eretz) which in English was translated as "In the beginning God created the heaven and the earth". It was the word ברא (bara) they argued should be translated as "separation" or "cutting" rather than created. This had made her very curious, not so much about the whole sentence as about the word ברא (bara). If there in Hebrew were possible to derive creation and separation from the same word, then the two concepts would need to have some kind of relationship to each other. This tickled her interest as an artist working with creation all day; How was separation part of that process?

She had decided to explore the question through her own making. She knew that a biblical scholar interested in understanding

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the word ברא (bara) wouldn't view ברא (bara) in solitude. Instead, they would look at the word in relation to the surrounding words making up the sentence. The scholar would also look at all the different places in the Hebrew Bible where the word ברא (bara) was found and then compare and contrast the meaning of each sentence. So she decided that her method should be similar, seen from a language point of view. To understand more about ברא (bara), she was not just going to explore ברא (bara), she was going to perform it. She was going to use cutting as her method of separation since the word ברא (bara) also could be translated as "cutting". The action of cutting was to be made on a weave, a piece of textile. To her, this was a kind of etymological humor as the word text is derived from the root textere, meaning to weave.

One day over dinner, she told her partner about her new project. He didn't say it out loud, but she could see by how he looked at her that something was bothering him. He had a keen interest in debating, so he pointed out that the prevalent view of language today, used by most linguists, is the idea that any language is a set of arbitrary but conventionally agreed upon words or "signs", that are linked together by a purely formal system of syntactic and grammatical rules. Language understood like this becomes a way of representing things and events in the perceived world. But it doesn't acknowledge any connection between the two, he pointed out. To him, it was evident that the perspective on language she was using in her project did not match that of contemporary linguists. When she had decided to explore the word ברא (bara) through a material inquiry, it meant that she thought it possible to learn something about a word by doing it. She was suggesting that words weren't arbitrary, but rather, on the contrary, could hold a correspondence to the material world. He did not agree to her stance, and so they ate the rest of their dinner in silence instead of arguing about it.

After dinner, she went into her studio to look for a piece of woven cloth to work with. What is special about woven textiles is that a weave results from two elements – the character of the fibers used in the thread and the construction of the weave. This makes the weave always portray how it has been made, and with what it has been made. During the years, she had collected many different



textiles; there were tons of them on her shelves. All in various colours, materials, and bindings. Now her eyes were drawn to the section of woven cloth that originally had been intended as canvases for painting. The canvases were made of linen that reflected light in a way cotton never could, but in a more demure way than any silk would. She picked out a selection of woven fabrics to which no color, pattern, or bleach had been added. Where the fibers were still close to their beginning.

She took one of the weavings, placed it on her desk, took up her scissors, and made a single cut in the middle of the fabric. She heard the small click the scissors made as the thread was cut in two. She then began to pull one of the thread's ends out from the weave's intersecting threads. Where the thread once was, there now was a void. As the fabric she had chosen was tightly woven, there was no way to cover up the void; she couldn't hide that there once was a thread in this part of the weave and now it wasn't. When she made a new cut somewhere else in the weave and a new void was created, the old one wouldn't stop existing. If she had worked in another material, this exact property wouldn't necessarily have been present. A much more porous material could have spilled out, hiding the void. That's how she realized the construction and the material are essential to how a separation utters itself.

When she had made a cut, she took the thread and started pulling it out of the weave, always with the other end still attached. This was a rule she created for herself, as one of the biblical scholars interviewed in the article had pointed out that the separation ברא (bara) characterized was a temporal process where initially two or more things were connected, but at the end were apart from each other. When she at one point started toying with the idea of cutting the thread in both ends, she wouldn't be doing ברא (bara) anymore, but rather בתק (bathaq), the Hebrew word for a separation that cuts a unity into two separate pieces. She knew that separation could be seen in a very specific kind of creation. The unity of an atom split into two. Fission. Separation, creation, and at the same time destruction. It's ironic how the word "atom" is derived from a Greek word that means "uncuttable", she thought. But she was also realizing how many words there were for sepa-



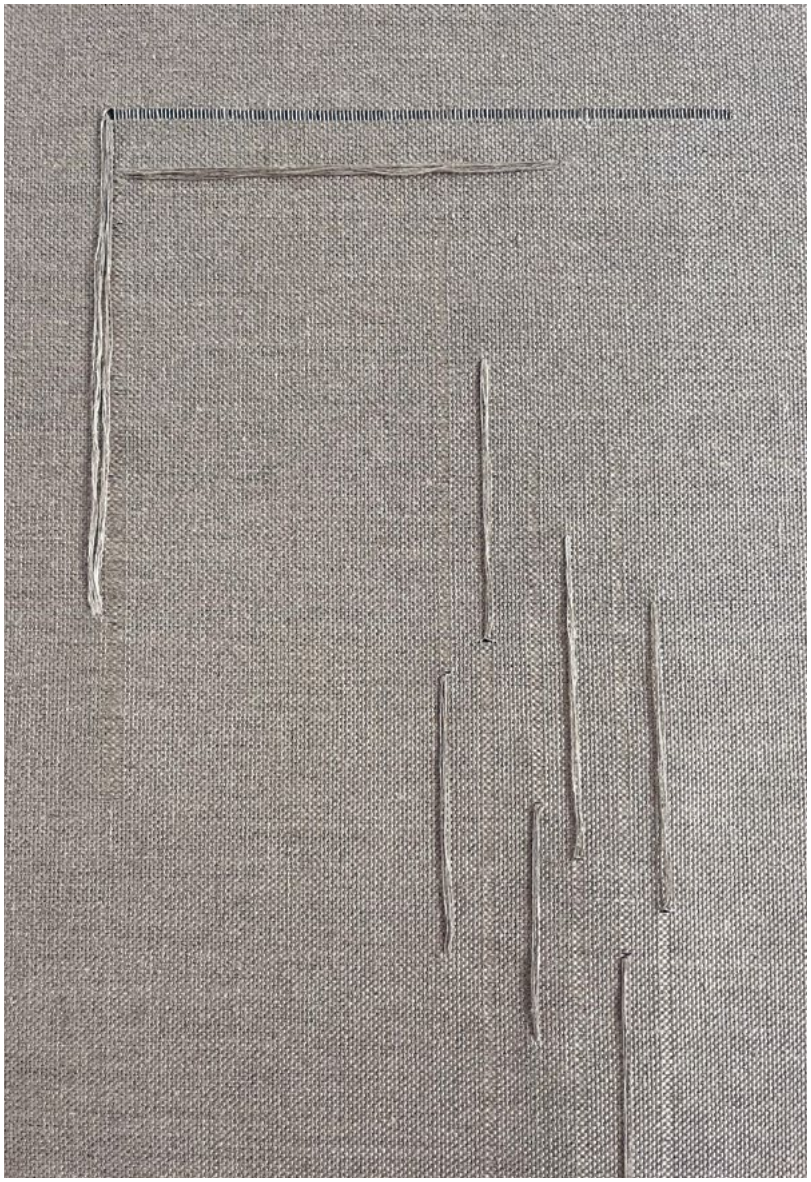
ration. In Hebrew, she, besides ברא (bara) and בתק (bathaq), also knew of the word בדל (badal), which describes a separation between already distinct objects, to put a distance between them. In her native Swedish, she could list words related to “skilja” such as “avskilja, urskilja, särskilja”. She found even more words in English: “split, cut, divide, part, cleave, sunder, chop”. What drives us to meticulously define the different ways it is possible to separate? she asked her partner when she returned home from her studio that evening.

The next day, she was back in her studio. Picking up where she left off, she took the separated threads and stitched them down in another part of the weave. The overlaying threads started creating new lines on the surface. All of the lines were straight; her technique prevented her from doing any curved forms, but it allowed her to play around with the width and length of the lines – lines made of distance. The separation started to create forms that filled the weavings she was working on. She perceived the forms as some kind of symbols. The problem was that she had no idea what the symbols meant, even if they were visual consequences of her own doing. Yet somehow, she recognized them, not with her mind, but with her body. Looking at them, she didn’t feel certainty; she felt truth, a kind of truth born from making.

Weeks passed, and during that time she had started to view the symbols as the source of the knowledge she was acquiring. What she was learning about the relationship between separation and creation was derived from her doing of ברא (bara). A doing which in turn produced the symbols. She had nailed a couple of the weavings to her studio wall, and as she one day stood looking at them from a distance, thought to herself that the symbols were a kind of cosmological equation, a symbol describing an origin. Ironically, she had hung the weavings next to a framed picture of parts of the equation that make up the ΛCDM (Lambda-CDM) model, a mathematical model of the Big Bang theory. The image had been a gift from her partner for their 5th anniversary.

She and her partner had met at a cosmology course at university some years earlier. Her subjects had been art and religion, his mathematics and philosophy. Cosmology was where their

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interest intersected. Looking at the ΛCDM (Lambda-CDM) model, she recalled some lines she had read in a book several nights earlier. The writer had been discussing that the scientific theory describing the beginning of the Universe – The Big Bang theory – exists primarily as a mathematical construct, since the earliest moments it describes are not directly accessible to observation. This means we must rely on the symbols that make up the equations as the generators of knowledge, because no one will ever witness the Big Bang itself. She saw very clearly that the insights she was making on the relationship between separation and creation were, in a way, the exact opposite. Her knowledge was empirical as it had been acquired through her own doing. It was possible for anyone else to repeat her actions. Still, her symbols functioned much like the cosmological equations, for those who hadn't been present in the studio would need to trust the symbols on the weave as the origin of the knowledge she had accumulated in her artistic research project. She understood her symbols were not cosmological as such. But she knew from the physicists who had been her teachers at university, they, just like her, wrestled with the question of correspondence. When she asked what correspondence a word might have to the world, they pondered the correspondence between mathematics and the Universe.

Suddenly, she was interrupted in her thinking as her partner swung the studio door open. Looking around, his half-eaten lunch sandwich in his hand, he saw the weavings nailed to the wall and took a few steps to inspect them. Every now and then, he came over to her studio sometime during lunch. He spent his days working from his study in their apartment, writing his dissertation in physics. His chosen topic was a mathematical investigation of Hubble's Law, a key part of the Big Bang theory. While the Big Bang theory describes the Universe's expansion, Hubble's Law explains that galaxies within it also move away from each other. The farther apart they are, the faster they recede. She had been mesmerized the first time he told her about those theories. It was precisely the movement she felt was happening in language. The more time passed since the days of the Garden of Eden, the further language was pushed away from humanity.

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She walked over next to him and told him about her inclination – that the symbols on her weavings were like a symbol in a cosmological equation.

Her hands moved across the weavings, and she said aloud a thought that had been growing inside her.

> "The symbols are portraying how they have been made through how they were made."

It didn't make sense, so she tried to explain.

> "A weave is the result of two elements – the character of the fibers used in the thread and the construction of the weave."
>
> "So the weave will always portray how it has been made, and with what it has been made."
>
> "Through my actions, I have only altered the threads of the weavings I have been working with, so you can see exactly what my actions have been."
>
> "That's why the symbols on the weavings are portraits of how the symbols have been made."

Her partner just stared, first at her, then at the weavings. Slowly, he collected himself and said with a firm voice,

> "You're reading too much into this. The weave doesn't portray anything; those marks are certainly not symbols or a cosmological equation.
>
> "It's just patterns you created."

He glanced over at the weavings again, frowning. His voice rose; he was almost shouting.

> "Symbols, just like words, don't create reality; they merely describe it."



> "You think you're creating knowledge through cutting fabric, but really, you're mistaking subjective experience for objective truth."

As he spoke, she felt as though the room itself was pulling away from her. She fell silent, her face flushing hot as she opened the door and left.

After a long walk through their neighbourhood, she returned to her studio a few hours later. The studio was empty, her partner had left. She sat down and stared at the weavings hanging on her wall, her hands restlessly twisting the fringes of an old blanket. Not only had she and her partner left each other under such bad terms, but the artistic research project deadline was drawing closer. Only this morning had she received a second reminder to e-mail a first draft for the paper she was supposed to present at a conference. Still, she hadn't written a single sentence as she had been so occupied working with her textiles.

Later in the evening, when she returned home, she found that her partner had gone to bed early. Just seeing him, she felt the anger flare up. To calm herself down, she climbed into bed, lit a candle, and read the book of Psalms. She was just starting to yawn when verse 13 of Psalm 139 caught her eye, which read, "You brought my inner parts into being; You wove me in my mother's womb." From her schooling, she remembered that the Latin word used in Vulgate (the Latin translation of the Bible), which in English was translated as "wove", was "orsus". A word that could mean both "beginning" and "word" as well as "warp and weft". She instantly felt more awake than she had all day. It was as though her whole project could be encompassed in the word "orsus". The weave's warp and weft had been the origin of the Universe in some cultures. In others, it had been the word. In "orsus", the word and the weave were the same, and at the same time, the beginning. This also meant that she didn't need to write that paper after all, she had done all of her writing through the weavings she had been working on. It was as though her weavings were her Adamic language. Her weavings had become her words, making the correspondence absolute. She got out of their bed and very quietly put on her clothes again. Words aren't arbitrary, she thought to

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herself, on the contrary, they are reality. She opened the door, leaving her partner sleeping in their bedroom, and headed towards her studio to continue her work.

Once she had asked her partner if they should get married in a church, he said he didn't believe in God, so what was the point? Argued it didn't mean anything, that in a secular society, religion has no power, no influence on people's lives. So they weren't husband and wife. She thought that might be why he kept telling her they were soulmates, to compensate somehow. The Swedish word for soulmate is "själsfrände". "Själ" is Swedish for soul, the word comes from the Norse word "sál". When the word "sál" made its way into Swedish sometime around the first millennium, it was through Christian missionaries who introduced both Christianity as well as the Latin alphabet, which came to replace the runic. Meaning that when the word "själ" is used in Swedish, the word per se is derived from the Christian understanding of what a soul is. The word and the concept are impossible to separate. In the end, she knew that despite their differences and contradictory perspectives, it was her partner's use of the word soulmate that would tear them apart. His persistent use of a word where half of it was derived from a concept he didn't believe in, derived from a religion he believed exercised no influence on him, was the word he used to define their relationship to each other. And at some point, it would be the final thread that would cause their whole fabric to unravel.

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TIMBER SEMIOTICS

VOID – FLUX – MARK

TOVA FRANSSON

TOVA FRANSSON
TIMBER SEMIOTICS
VOID - FLUX - MARK

KLARÄLVEN [THE CLEAR RIVER]

On the wall next to my bed, I have a map of Värmland.[1] It was originally drawn in 1808. I see it every night when I fall asleep and every morning when I wake up. It's perhaps outdated as a map in some respects, municipalities – districts – towns – names and roads have changed and expanded, grown or disappeared. Down the middle you see Klarälven running through the whole county. The river stretches nearly 300 kilometers from Långflon in the farthest north down to Vänern, Sweden's largest lake, in the south. From Sysslebäck to Edebäck, in the so called Klarälv basin, the river is made up of a nearly 90-kilometer meandering stretch. A stretch in constant fluxus. I grew up just past the hydroelectric power plant at its end.

There is a new clear-cut on Middagsberget. It's huge and next to our cross-country ski trail. But this winter we can't make any tracks on the road with it's perfectly balanced inclines, gentle hills and moderate turns. The timber lorries run a shuttle service around the clock. They go by at high speed, thunder past Rufus and Sirkka[2] in the yard and stop for nothing. Shift work in the lorry cabin. You can't afford to let a timber lorry stand still. The road is narrow and made of gravel. Winter road. Perfect for snowmobiles and trips up the mountains, to the marshes, the lakes, the forest which you can't reach by car.

Östersjön – Mellansjön – Kuntknölen.

Now we drive past fast as hell. Afraid of meeting one of the timber lorries and not have enough space on the road. From the early 1600s until 1991 the river transported timber to the many paper and pulp industries in Värmland through log driving on Klarälven.[3] It was the last of the logging stretches in Sweden. I remember the timber floating down the river. I saw the large storage of logs just before the bridge.

1 Värmland is a county in west central Sweden. I grew up there. Paradisheden was our farm and it was my job to boil the potatoes for the pigs.

2 Rufus is a Jack Russel Terrier. Sirkka is a Finnish Spitz.

3 Lundén, Bo (1986) *Flottningen på Klarälven*, utgiven av Klarälvens flottarförening med bidrag från Billerud AB, STORA och Uddeholms AB, Karlstad, p. 12.



SIGNALARTER [INDICATOR SPECIES]

There is no exact English word for the Swedish term signalarter, but ISOF defines it as indicator species.[4] The term is used for species that indicate biotopes with high nature value.

Vascular plants – bryophytes – lichen – fungi – insects.

In the autumn I go to the print workshop Grafikverkstan Godsmagasinet in Uttersberg on a residency. My plan: a letterpress printed work depicting Klarälven and its shape. I'm working with the meandering stretch Sysslebäck–Edebäck. I want to use signalarter typically associated with and namely used as indicators of forests containing high environmental value. From The Swedish Forest Agency, I collect a list of 333 species and their recommended Swedish name.[5]

I want to stay true to the shape of the river, but don't really care about it being correct in all aspects, so I choose to work with the left edge as a starting point for the text. I want the full form to fit in a flow from top to bottom – left to right. I use a map made by Åke Sundborg in 1956. It was constructed as a part of a research project on Klarälvens meandering spanning 150 years.[6] My friend Emil gives it to me. He works with roads and infrastructure in Värmlands county board and is very interested in the river.[7] The map gives me the form and I set the format. It ends up being 3 meters and 65 centimeters long. I rework the original for some time and then choose a format for the paper. Make a mockup to determine what font size, and indeed what font to use.

4 ISOF (The Institute for Language and Folklore) – *Signalart* https://www.isof.se/svenska-spraket/fackspra k-och-terminologi/termgrupper-och-organisationer/hallbarhetstermgruppen/hallbarhetstermlistan/termer/signalart [accessed 2024-11-01].

5 *Signalarter – Skogsstyrelsen* https://www.skogsstyrelsen.se/globalassets/miljo-och-klimat/nyckelbitoper/skogsstyrelsens-signalarter---version2023-1.pdf [accessed 2024-10-29].

6 Sundborg, Åke (1957) *Klarälven under 150 år – en erosionskarta med beskrivning*, Wretmans boktryckeri AB, Uppsala.

7 "Exciting! I can send more material on the subject. The Swedish Transport Administration (Trafikverket) is applying for a permit to protect RV 62 from falling into the river, and they need to demonstrate how much the erosion protection hinders the natural meandering process. These old maps are part of the documentation, as they show where the river erodes and where it deposits eroded sand, and how the meander bends slowly move downstream. It's fascinating how flow dynamics work. When you harden curves to protect the road from eroding into the river,the water's kinetic energy has to go somewhere else. Either some property is damaged by increased erosion, or the erosion moves to the middle and depth of the river, making it deeper. This is what Trafikverket claims is happening here. Constant energy moves along with the water anyway."

TOVA FRANSSON
TIMBER SEMIOTICS
VOID - FLUX - MARK

I know I want a standard font. A small one. Small enough so that you can't make out the text until you're up close.

For those who live near the river, the threat of flooding is always present. The currents of Klarälven are strong and capricious. You learn that. It moves and forms temporary islands of sand. Sometimes you can easily walk across the river without dipping your head under water; sometimes it's too dangerous to swim there. I remember the spring flood in 1995 and how my friends had to get in a rowing boat at their doorstep and row to the school bus. I was jealous. I search the workshop looking for something that would best suit the river. When working in letterpress you are always working with constraints. Each workshop has a certain number of fonts in various type sizes, and when choosing one you must work backwards. What are you going to write? How long will your text be? How many a's do you need? Are there enough in the type case? I choose folio in 6 pt. There are plenty of a's.

Get ready to set the text. How to do that? The typeface is very small. I mark the edge, decide a length for the form of types and spacing, and adjust accordingly when the river flows to the left or right. I need to keep the edge always aligned and not create problems for myself later in the process. 5 konk is enough.[8] It holds all the text. I mark the mirrored left edge of the river on a paper. Cut it to size. The paper is put in the composing stick so I can follow the water.[9] I want to have options on where to put the text. I want options for the presentation. Horizontally – vertically. To be able to choose in which direction the river flows.

Do I keep the tributaries?

8 In Sweden (and Europe, but not the UK), we use the Cicero system as a unit of measurement in typography and printing. The system was introduced in the 18th century, and in this system, one point equals 0.376 mm (rounded up). One cicero is 12 points, or 4.513 mm. A konk equals 4 ciceros, that is, 48 points, or 18.052 mm. 1 konk = 18.052 mm, and 5 konk = 90.26 mm.

9 A composing stick is a small tray of sorts where the form, your typeface, is set and held together.

I only use lower case.[10] I randomly choose from my list of species. Tick them off, one by one. Trying to learn them by heart. The names flow in and out of my mind, sometimes they make sense. Sometimes I already know what they look like. Mostly I don't. I spell them out. One letter at a time. Mind the spacing. Broken l's and mixed-up f's and g's. Someone at one point switched the compartments. The lead types are dirty; I do have gloves.

I of course keep the tributaries.

The river is stored on the galley,[11] marked with numbers on surgical tape for me to remember the order. A new part of the river takes form. I've passed Uggenäs and Likenäs, heading into Möre, where I've never been before. I repeat the words. Again, and again. I put them together. Pick them apart. My rhythm is their rhythm. My feet are sore, and my hips hurt. Standing up at a letterpress cabinet for 10+ hours does that to you. You can't speed the process up. Just follow along and let it take the time needed. Set the type. Make sure it's aligned. Print. And repeat.

Finally, Öjenäs – Ämtbjörk – Gunnerud.

I try it out on different papers. A fluorescent yellow one that I find in one of the bottom drawers in the workshop. Nice paper, French made. A yellowed paper where the edges have a shadow, Dutch made. And Grums made, a paper that I collected from Gruvöns bruk in Värmland.[12] Their scraps. It's not wood-free and most definitely not lightfast. Henric brought it for me on the bus. Carried the log. I try black and fluorescent orange ink. Black it is. I decide to go with the fluorescent yellow paper. It's raining outside again.

Ö-VIK

During the winter, I have somehow ended up trying to work in a different way than I usually do. It's weird and clearly not working

10 Upper Case and Lower Case – terms for the different types of letters based of the position of an individual type case above or below the other. Capital letters were stored in the upper case and smaller letters in the lower case.

11 A lightweight metal tray with three closed edges where you store your form inbetween printing.

12 Billerud AB is a Swedish pulp and paper manufacturer, and one of it's factories is located on Gruvön, right next to Vänern, in the urban area Grums, in Southern Värmland.

TOVA FRANSSON
TIMBER SEMIOTICS
VOID - FLUX - MARK





to my advantage. I go to Örnsköldsvik on another residency at a printmaking studio, can't get started, doubt my plan and my motivation is at a zero. I visit the local water park instead and lay there in the outside infinity pool and fantasize about working as a lifeguard. Snow is falling.

It's my second-to-last day in Ö-vik. I'm bored and starting to feel like myself again. I've exhausted the pre-made plans trying to get back into that state of unknowing where the next step will take me, a state I really like to be in and work from. Where a flow works in my favor. One thing leading to another, me not particularly focusing on the next step until I'm there. Which means I want to explore the printshop, see what it can give me. Searching the letterpress cabinets at ÖKKV.[13] I see the typical set ups you usually find in workshops inherited from an old printing house:

futura – times new roman – garamond – berlings antikva – bold – italic – condensed – wood type – no name type – gothic (sans serif) – condensed gothic – italian. They communicate a flow of information.

In the bottom drawer to the left, in front of the windows leading out to the waiting hall of the new train station, there's a wooden box with two small brass shackle locks. I love boxes. Especially boxes you find in letterpress workshops. They are forgotten treasures, forgotten functions. Something to unlock and discover. Maybe the meaning of the objects has long been lost, irrelevant, completely out of use. In the box is a complete list of Örnsköldsvik's Tree Surveyors' Association between 1953–54. Small lead cast types of sorts that identify owners of forest land: smallholders, timber companies, or other kinds of associations. Symbols for marking.[14] Could this be the link that I have been looking for? A language for the forest.

13 ÖKKV – Örnsköldsviks kollektivverkstad.

14 I email EXPO (a non-profit foundation and magazine working against rasism and xenofobia): "Hi Tova, and thanks for your question! It's more than fine for you to email. Sounds like a fun project, nice to see the old symbols. After looking at the PDF, my first thought is that it's probably just mark 152 that might vaguely resemble the so-called wolf's hook. Originally, the wolf's hook had nothing to do with Nazism but was appropriated, like so many other runes and old symbols, by the Nazis. Other than that, I don't see any symbols that I believe anyone would reasonably react to (aside from the ones you've already mentioned). I hope this was helpful. All the best, Morgan."

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TIMBER SEMIOTICS

In the practice of log driving all sorts of tree trunks are transported in hoops. In order for confusion to be minimized you need a system for marking the timber. This has historically been carried out in different ways and through various methods and it is still used in modern forest industry. Up until the latter part of the 1900s it was commonly done by marking axes in the case of log driving. The mark of the owner as well as the classification of the particular log. An imprint in wood. An end mark.

The flow – the flux. From some sort of chaos to regulated system. A river's own choreography. The formless shape traveling in a mass, breaking up, trailing away, bumping into whatever comes its way. Some timber sinks. It can't hold the amount of water weighing it down, I guess. You can pick them up later. Or leave them for the fish.

A classification made with markings.
A quality is assessed.
A price is determined.
Make the mark.

I hear the best book to read up on the log driving on Klarälven is Bo Lundén's comprehensive book from 1986: *Flottningen på Klarälven*. Lundén was a previous logging manager[15] and had over 60 years of experience in the industry. He describes the logging history dating back to the early 1600s up until 1986. I borrow the book from my local library. They fetch it from the storage. On the last page, I find a paragraph that someone wrote in blue ink. When written, the pressure from the pen was hard and it left a mark on the previous page, like a colorless imprint in the paper.

15 Lundén was the head of Klarälvens log driving association (KFF – Klarälvens flottningsförening) between the years 1952–1980.

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VOID - FLUX - MARK

Flottningen lades ner
mot bättre vetande hösten 1991.
Visat boken för författaren som
blev glad att se den men bedrövad
o. förbannad av beslutet.
Den enda flottgods ägaren var
på slutet STORA KOPPARBERG.
Som ägde skoghall.
Må förbannelse vila över deras
beslut att köra på bil och kortsiktigt
tjäna snabba pengar.
"Pråmskepparn"[16]

THE AXE

I want to find marking axes from Värmland and my first impulse is to call my mum. She is the one to talk to. She knows everyone and always comes up with good ideas on who to contact. She probably already knows them, and if not, she soon will.

Our neighbors Peter and Ingegärd own at least three marking axes. One they can reach for now, the others are snowed in. Heavy snowfall and rain. There's at least one meter of hard ice blocking the barn. I can have them in the spring. They live on top of the hill on the other side of the river. We cross the steel bridge in -25. The snow creaks under snowmobile boots and the fluctuating surface beneath us is nearly completely frozen.

I can surely make my way to the axes?
Should I just go there? Chop through ice.

My mother puts me in contact with Joe[17] at the local folk museum. He hooks me up with five more and throws in "a really good book" about the log driving from Norway down Klarälven. My matrix will be the axe. My method; chopping?

16 English translation: The log driving was discontinued in bad faith by the autumn of 1991. Shown the book to the author who was glad to see it but devastated an' accursed by the decision.The only log driving owner in the end was STORA KOPPARBERG. That owned Skoghall. May the curse rest upon their decision to turn to cars and in the short run make some easy money. "Pråmskepparn".

17 Pronunciation: [joə]





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VOID - FLUX - MARK

THE MATRIX

Copper and wood. Common matrices used in printmaking. Can I use the marking axes as a matrix, and what will be the finished print? Do I need one?

I put together a glulam board from wood collected from the sawmill in Årjäng. I see it from the window of my office. The air heavy of steam – smoke – vapour. They water the logs to prevent them from rotting. I got the wood from Jens. It's of poor quality and quite soft. Lots of knags and resin. I've never made one before. We use the scraps and put together a one by half a meter wonky sheet of spruce. It's perfect.

I get a copper sheet, 5 mm. It might work. I book the project space at my collective studio for a few days. It's nice to start with the void and fill it up as I go, to be able to see what happens when I do. I circulate, round and round. Pick up trestles and boards from my studio next door. Place the axes on a raised sheet of plywood. My material. How to do it? I line them up, decide on a distance and start chopping. I use them on several smaller wooden planks that I got from my mother's and Johan's forest. The one they cut down and built a house out of. Their neighbor Alf split the trunks into planks in his water powered sawmill. He regulates the flux. Constantly checks the weather and cleans the river and its tributaries. He's getting old and has no one to hand it all down to. They're so dense. Old forest that's been left standing. It makes an excellent material for wood paneling that holds up for most things. I pound it and make frottages with graphite and charcoal on the ugly paper from Grums. I'm kneeling on the floor and use scraps. It feels chaotic and messy. But it looks nice, and I immediately want it to be paired with the nice wood. I mark the wood with fluorescent yellow and glue the paper to it. The board glows.

I polish the copper for at least an hour. It already has a few dents because it's so thin, it doesn't matter. The copper carries so many connotations that it's hard to start chopping away, but I do it anyway. Thankful for the dents. Carefully choose a spot that feels good, a bit over the golden ratio, I think. I make the mark. The copper bends and flows up and down, distorting my reflection.

SORTING THE RIVER

When setting a text in letterpress you always have to sort your text back into the type case. This is tedious. Takes a lot of time. If you try to take a short cut, you will inevitably give yourself more work in the end. It's not worth it.

I go back to Uttersberg again to sort the river. I follow the words, look at the head of each font. Each letter by each letter down they go, back into small wooden compartments. My hands know what to do. I'm quite quick. I optimize every movement. Straight back. Crack the neck. Situate my hips. a to a, m to m. If I drop one in the wrong compartment it's nearly impossible to find it again.

The sheer amount of
m – o – s – s – a
and
b – a – g – g – e
and
s – k – ö – l – d – i – n – g
makes the movements more or less automatic.

I think of the workers sorting the timber. I read their work was very monotonous and their heads and eyes hurt from looking at the ends of logs all day long.[18] It must have been hard work to identify the small markings made by axes. Easier when they switched to paint. I'm nearly done and the piles of spacing on the galley next to me are huge. I almost used all of them. It looks like it's going to rain.

THE NEW AXES

My mother texts me. The sharp ice has melted. I have four more.

18 Lundgren Landin, Helena (2018) *Lustenbåtarna på Klarälven,* Votum & Gullers förlag, Karlstad, p. 14.

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AS AMERICAN AS____

HEATHER JONES

HEATHER JONES
AS AMERICAN AS____

AUTHOR'S NOTE:

My interest in craft is not craft per se, but stories. In particular, I am drawn to the way that stories have a habit of clinging to materials. This is especially true of stories that exist outside of the annals of recorded history, either because they are not deemed historically worthy, or because they have been purposefully and systematically erased. In their search for refuge, they embed themselves in unexpected places, surviving through the materials they inhabit.

My initial idea for this year-long artistic research project was to combine methodologies of re-creation of historical textiles as referenced in the work of archeologist Elizabeth Wayland Barber[1] and the artist Sunny Smith[2] with archival research and creative writing through the method of critical fabulation, as outlined by African American scholar Saidiya Hartman.[3]

In short: making on the one hand, research and creative writing on the other.

I decided to "dig where I stand"[4] when I found an unfinished double wedding ring quilt top in my parents upstairs bedroom. It was begun by my great-great grandmother who at the time I knew very little about. I began simultaneously working on this quilt and researching the woman who made it – details of her life and the socio-cultural context in which this quilt was created. I searched through genealogy records, cardboard boxes of dot matrix print-outs and grainy photographs, piles of newspaper clippings and journal articles, and I endlessly bothered a very kind librarian at the Indiana State Historical Archives. Perhaps

1 Barber, 1992, 1995.

2 Smith views craft as a means of projecting oneself both backwards and forwards. They credit historical recreation and reenactment as actually always being about the present in their potential to destabilize master narratives. Speaking specifically about quilts and echoing Rogoff's theories, Smith states, "The 'quilt' holds the residue of that experience, giving the art object an artifact quality that points back to the conditions and conversations of its making." Smith, 2017.

3 I was and continue to be uncomfortable about using Hartman's theories outside of their original context of reclaiming the narratives of enslaved African-American women. Over the course of this project I have found other potential methodological frameworks, none of which however engage in creative writing and the instrumentalization of the imagination as a critical tool.

4 First published in 1978, this manifesto argues that the tools of critical and rigorous historical inquiry are accessible to everyone—not just academics—and can be applied to local, economic, and familial histories. Lindqvist, 2023.

most importantly, I talked to family members and recorded oral interviews with the last remaining people who knew her. My research highlight: a single audio recording of my great-great grandmother created shortly before her death. The slow lilt and drawl of her voice became intrinsic to my research process.

By all accounts, my great-great grandmother was a loving wife, mother, grandmother, church member, cook, and upstanding citizen. What I uncovered below the surface was a complex narrative that may be true, *or not*. My research began to reveal a darkly mundane history with links to white supremacy, violence, the prison system, and how these threads were inseparable from the myth of the American ideal. Unsurprisingly, many of these stories and details have been hidden or erased from both physical evidence and cultural / familial memories. It was essential to engage with critical fabulation and the use of the subjunctive mood in the writing to suggest that something *could* be true, while also pointing to the lack of empirical evidence – *or not*. This research, rooted in a lack of information, necessitated the creation of a new methodology and demanded a reconfiguration of "how to know".[5]

So, knowing very little, how could I come to know?

Simultaneous to this research (which I nicknamed 'paper-research'), I stitched, working to finish the quilt that she had started approximately 100 years ago ('body/blood/memory/spirit research'). I had an intuition that by putting my body through the same motions of her body, I would somehow be able to more accurately guess, imagine, and access details of her story that were missing, of which there are many. The hours upon hours of sewing by hand came to serve as a ligament between my body and hers, as a time travel mechanism, and ultimately as a permission to slip inside this woman's life and see it from the inside out. As I write

5 My research methodology was deeply inspired by Irit Rogoff's perspective of research as an emergent process that reflects its own conditions. In the lecture 'Becoming Research' (Rogoff 2019), Rogoff notes the necessity of a departure from research that is "verifiable, and therefore valuable" towards research in which the methodology and outcome reflect the conditions of research, including research rooted in precarity and a *lack* of verifiable information. When researching from within unstable or missing conditions, Rogoff's position is that it is essential to move from working with inherited knowledges towards working with methods that reflect these conditions.

this, the middle finger of my right hand and the pointer finger of my left still bear the calluses of this solicitation.

Although I set out to learn about my great-great grandmother, it slowly became clear to me that by following the single thread of her life, I was following the history of America, including the violent systems, both blatant and banal, that have and continue to be used to propagate a nationalist ideal. The title of the project, *As American As____*, references common phrases like "As American as quilting" or "As American as apple pie" – both things for which my great-great grandmother is fondly remembered. In the field of academic quilt research, it's well known that quilts have been used as a prop for a nostalgic, nationalist image-making project. In my research, I connect this patchwork quilt to a much more complex and layered narrative of American history and culture. Readers can fill in the blank in the title as they see fit.

Over the course of this year-long research, I saw the thread of this narrative continue to play out: A wrongfully accused man was executed in my home state of Missouri despite serious legal concerns. Donald Trump was elected for a second term, promising to "Make America Great Again", followed by his administration's systematic removal of historical information that "no longer serves the interest of the United States" from educational institutions and museums, including several of the images referenced in this text.[6]

In light of this deeply concerning political turn, it was important to me to not only reveal hidden potential narratives, but also imagine alternatives,[7] no matter how impossible they may seem. Sewing and writing can both become acts of repair. I wondered, if my great-great-grandmother were still here, what she would think of my research, of the state of our country. Knowing what little I do know about her, what action would she take?

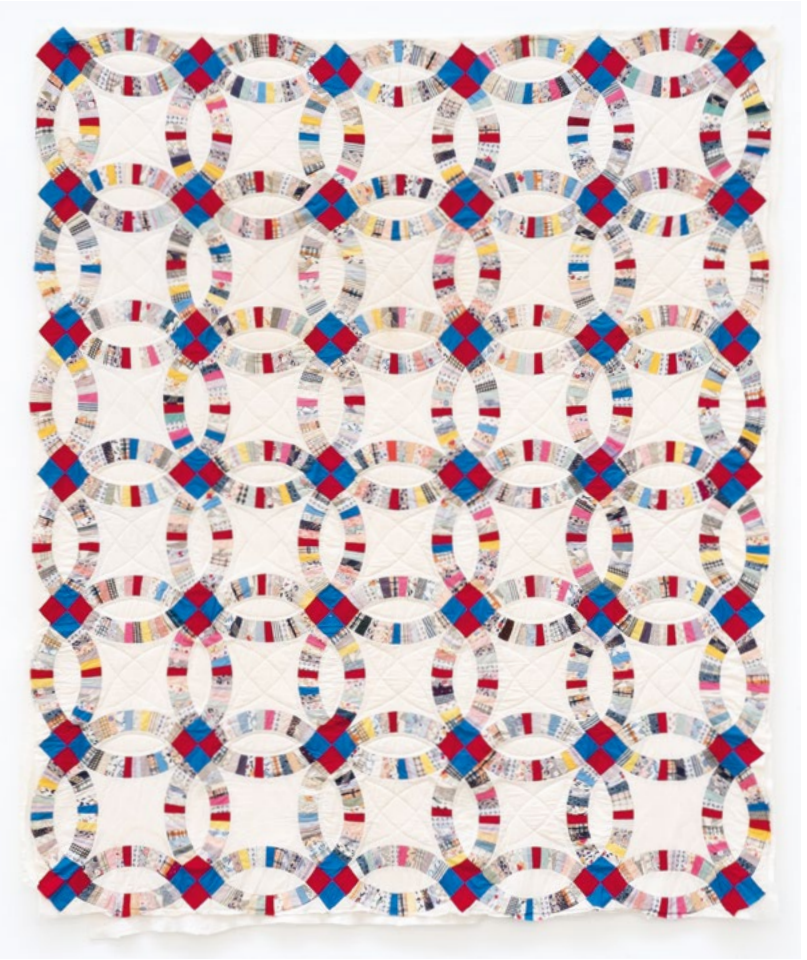
6 As of March 2025, the Trump administration has introduced legislation removing financial support for "exhibits or programs that degrade shared American values, divide Americans based on race, or promote programs or ideologies inconsistent with Federal law and policy." Under particular attack is the Smithsonian Institution's National Museum of African American History and Culture.
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7 Olufemi, 2021.

What is presented here is a research project in process. As of now, it has taken the form of the original double wedding ring quilt, now finished; a semi-fictional text based on the familial, archival, and imaginal research that I engaged in; and a new, unfinished additional quilt[8] as the thread of this story continues to unspool.

8 This unfinished quilt features the beginning of a lemon pie recipe, which my great-great grandmother was locally known for. I do not have her actual recipe, but I found this recipe in The Farmer's Guide New Cookbook, published in Huntington, IN in 1945. The cookbook consists of "tested recipes" compiled by the housewives of Huntington, none of whose names are listed, so it could be her recipe, or not.

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It disappeared, popped its head up only to dive under the surface again, emerging sharply once more, a little to the left.

Most stories are like this.

The thread continued in this way for many thousands of years before landing in the hand of Mabel Van Pelt's mother Lucy Ann Campbell as she crudely lashed the canvas tarp onto the wagon's frame. This was not artistry – there was a storm coming and Pratt County, Kansas was, and continues to be, notoriously flat. The war between the states had been over for 20 years by that point, and Melvin deemed that Kansas had stopped bleeding enough to homestead. This was likely 1883, or 84, or 85. Threads don't care about dates like we do.

Mabel Van Pelt wasn't called that back then. In fact, she wasn't called anything at all until she was born on the 27th of September, or maybe it was April, 1887, at which point she was named Mabel Abigail Roth.

Mabel didn't see the thread until it was handed to her on the journey back to Indiana. Same wagon, same kind of storm. She was 5. John was older and better suited to the task, but he was sick, and Billy was only a baby and not yet good for much, so that left her. The thread was thick and her fingers were small enough to push it through the nail holes Pa hammered in the makeshift leather shoes for the lame colt. She didn't remember the Ghost Dance Wars, Wounded Knee, or any of the reasons they left. Fires on the side of the path, all their belongings in the back, the pull of that thick thread, the lame colt – that's what she remembered first.

LOST IMAGE:
"That's what makes me feel so bad that I lost that picture. Had a picture taken of Frank and me and Bill a-sittin' in a highchair in the photography home, how they sit 'em up there, you know. And Frank beside me. And I don't know what happened to it."

They got back just in time for Orville to be born, who they called Dutch. Then they came thick and fast: Eva, Florence Esther, Evan, Earl or Ike who died 2 years later, then Beulah Mae, and Josephine. That bedroom was like a factory, neighbors said. Mabel quit school so she could keep up. She may have been happy about leaving school, no longer getting her braids pulled and face washed in snow by James.

Or not.

Mabel's parents rented a house up north on Main. On the other side of the street, Mabel's father Charles built a house on his off hours from Godfrey's flour mill, which wasn't much. They moved in before the lathe was done and Mabel would pull out her trundle bed and fall asleep, sawdust and all. All that time Mabel kept hold of that thread, pushed it through patches, stitches getting smaller and faster as her hands grew, played the piano in the parlor on days it was heated, learned to cook, and walked down the path in her church clothes every Sunday.

Between Earl's burial and Beulah Mae's birth, Mabel turned 19 and James Robert Van Pelt came home from the Spanish-American war, addicted to morphine but still very handsome. Jim's father called her over on the street saying "Mabel, Jim's coming home tomorrow!" To which Mabel replied, "What do I care? I got a beau that's prettier." She changed her tune the next day when she looked up from the double swing her father had made and saw Jim coming across the back lot in his uniform. "My lands!" she said. "My lands! There's Jim."

They went uptown that very same night. After that, he'd rent a horse and buggy and they'd go around together. A few days or maybe it was weeks later, Jim told Mabel that they were engaged, and that he was taking the train to Indianapolis to break things off with his girlfriend. Mabel might have been shocked he had a girl, or not. Either way, it gave her time to call things off with Charlie Grimes over in Rensselaer so it worked out alright.

The others didn't like it one bit but after 2 or 3 months, Mabel and Jim were hitched and that was that. On the day they got married, Mabel may have had a baker's dozen quilts like she was supposed to.

Or not.

James married her regardless. People started calling her Mrs. Van Pelt then, which made Mabel feel like something special.

Mabel kept hold of that thread, kept it in her pocket when she went to work at her Uncle Bill's restaurant. She baked pies and waited tables and that all suited her just fine.

When Mabel was 21, she gave birth to her first child, a daughter she named Irene. It happened in Monticello, at home of course. It was hard work, but Mabel was used to hard work and did what had to be done, just like always. The following year her son Marion was born, no location listed, which means he was also born at home. Mabel's youngest sister Josephine was born not two months later, and Mabel would sometimes watch all three of them, rocking, stitching, rocking, stitching.

Between 1909 and 1914 the thread became less visible... not much happened on the stage of the world but in Mabel's realm, children grew, clothes got torn and mended, food got cooked, floors got scrubbed, and in the small room off to the side of the kitchen, small scraps of fabric got patched into patterns and even smaller scraps of time were saved for her own thoughts, prayers, maybe even a nap though she'd never admit it.

1914 saw the war to end all wars, which of course, didn't. Mabel was 27 then and really didn't have time for a war but she pledged allegiance and planted her victory garden (which was really just the same as her regular garden but now it had a flag in it).

A year later, after all that and with the war still dragging on, Jim moved Mabel and the two kids to Huntington. Marion started at the new school the very day he turned 6. He squalled but he got over it. Sometimes you just have to – both squall and get over it.

They lived on the corner of Tipton right across from Dick Rayder's while they built a living place right onto an old barn. Jim got a job at the Erie (RR) and Mabel had to get up mornings and get breakfast and fix lunch, all before he walked to work before dawn. Didn't even have a bicycle then. After four years of that, they were able to move into the new house.

While Mabel was moving and Marion was squalling, the Indiana Knights of the Ku Klux Klan were mustering. In 1918, 328 residents of Huntington signed a petition demanding "the removal of all negroes." It passed of course, Indiana being the strongest Klan in all 48 states, and Huntington proudly became an official sundown town until 1968 but really until the 1980s.

Now there's no record that Jim joined the KKK, and there's no record that he didn't.

> *Thank you for contacting the Indiana Historical Society. The existence of Klan records from various Indiana locations is very scattered. Many of the location's records have been lost, purposely destroyed, or have not yet come to light. We do not have Huntington County membership records. We do have a ledger that shows the leadership in each part of the state for 1925, of which Huntington County is included. The noted membership for the county at that time was 1,025 members, but leadership consisted of only 13 men. There weren't any VanPelts or Roths in the list of leaders within the Huntington County Klan. Unless records are unearthed in the future, there would be little to no way to determine if the speculation regarding membership is accurate.*

He might have joined the clan.

IMAGE: Recruiting card for the Ku Klux Klan. A wove paper recruiting card created by the Ku Klux Klan. The card shows black ink printed on a white background, landscape orientation and reads:

Form P-217A 400M 4-20-23
Largely titled in uppercase bold:
"NON SILBA SED ANTHAR"
Below the title is a statement: Your friends state that you are a "Native Born" American Citizen, having he best interest of your Community, City, State and Nation at heart, owing no allegiance to any foreign government, political party, sect, creed or ruler, and engaged in a legitimate occupation, and believe in: –viz

The tenets of the Christian Religion.
White supremacy.
Protection of our pure womanhood.
Just Laws and Liberty.
The upholding of the Constitution of these United States.
The Separation of Church and State.
The Freedom of Speech and Press.
Closer relationship between Capital and American Labor.
Preventing the causes of mob violence and lynchings.
Preventing unwarranted strikes by foreign labor agitators.
Prevention of fires and destruction of property by lawless elements.
The limitation of foreign immigration.
The much needed local reforms.
Law and order.

REAL MEN whose oaths are inviolate are needed. Upon these beliefs and the recommendations of your friends, you are given an opportunity to become a member of the most powerful secret, non-political organization in existence, one that has the "Most Sublime Lineage in History," one that was "Here Yesterday," "Here Today," "Here Forever." Present this card at door for admittance, with your name, occupation, and address.

Towards the bottom of the card are blank spaces atop wide dotted lines, for the name, occupation, and address of the solicited. The back of the card is blank.

Or not.

And if he did, she might have joined too.

IMAGE: A small booklet of printed black text on white paper. Large black text at the top of the cover reads "Women of America! / The past! The present! / The Future!" At the center of the cover is a black and white image of a blindfolded woman holding a torch above her head with her right hand. In her left hand, she is holding a shield. Printed in black text at the bottom of the page is "Outline of Principles and Teachings / Women of the Ku Klux Klan / Incorporated / Issued by the Imperial Headquarters Women of / the Ku Klux Klan, Little Rock, Ark." The image and text is surrounded by a checkered border. The booklet has sixteen pages. The first page reads:

Largely titled in bold: To The Women of America:

THE INVISIBLE EMPIRE, WOMEN OF THE KU KLUX KLAN, through their Imperial Officers, take this occasion to salute you.

In presenting to you this little pamphlet of the PRINCIPLES AND TEACHINGS of this order we realize that the subject is too large to be fully covered at this time and in this way.

To fully appreciate the workings of this great order or womanhood it will be necessary for you to affiliate with and become a working element within the domain of the Invisible Empire.

We will gladly welcome all good women, who can qualify for membership, to join us in our efforts to promote the object and ideals as set forth herein. We invite all good women regardless of race, nationality, or creed to assist us by their influence in the promotion of these great principles and lofty ideals.

Here woman reigns, the mother, daughter, wife.

The last page reads:

ONLY NATIVE BORN WHITE WOMEN OF THE PROTESTANT FAITH ARE ELIGIBLE TO MEMBERSHIP IN THE INVISIBLE EMPIRE, WOMEN OF THE KU KLUX KLAN.

Or not.

Regardless, she might have skillfully stitched around the eyeholes to prevent fraying and altered the neckline for a better fit.

IMAGE: A Ku Klux Klan (KKK) hood with attached mask (a) and a hood liner (b). The hood is conical-shaped with a back flap with rounded corners. It has been made from plain, white cotton and has a red colored, cotton tassel attached at the point of the hood. Six and a half centimeter, round eye holes have been cut out of the front of the mask and stitched to prevent fraying. The white hood liner has been shaped using buckram, edged at the crown in brown, painted canvas.

Or not.

She may have attended the quilting bee to help raise funds for the local effort. Maybe she embroidered her name.

IMAGE: Signature fundraising quilt honoring the KKK. The fundraising organization for this quilt is stitched in the sixth row and the fourth square from the right – embroidered carefully here is a Klan member clothed in a hood, holding a large cross atop a horse – there is a second block diagonally up to the left side of this block, which reads, "Chicora KKK 1926."

Or maybe not.

Like I said, the thread isn't always visible.

Now pay attention because a lot happened that next year. First of all, liquor was outlawed. Second, Mabel got the right to vote but didn't. Jim voted for both of them of course, and even so, she wouldn't even know how to go about it. Most notably for Mabel, Jim traded in their horse and wagon for a Ford Model A, the first family on their end of town to get one. Soon after, Mabel set down her needle and thread, temporarily of course, double-checked to make sure that the oven was off and the Jim wasn't due back for a while. She'd been watching and this was her chance. She got in, put it in first and left it there, drove over to Oak Street, turned north while the engine growled and jerked. She drove up the street and back down and stopped. The next time, she went up Oak, took a left on Edith Avenue, and down Lafountaine and then stopped again to catch her breath. She sat

there, studied and studied, and when she was ready, went right around again. This time she turned on Tipton Street and got on Jefferson where they had a lot of cars. Mabel's heart was "going pitty pat" and the tires were bouncing on the paving brick. When Jim came home, he asked her how she liked driving the car. "Car?" she said. "Why, I didn't drive the car!" "Yes you did, now!" he replied. Of course Mrs. Tipton on the corner ratted her out, just like always.

Image: Map of Huntington, IN.

When Mabel was 36 her mother died back in Monticello. No good reason why. Sometimes people just wear out. Mabel got some of her quilts then, and tried to make her own stitches smaller. Mabel quilted when her children were sick, quilted when no one was home, quilted after dinner when her husband was done chiming his fork against his glass for another portion. Life continued on like that, days, weeks and months, cooking, cleaning, playing the piano in church, the thread going up and down, up and down.

On November 28, 1928 Mabel's daughter Irene married George Clarence Wood. Mabel was skeptical at first but she figured it was alright after all. A year later she had a grandson, James Covert Wood born at home in Huntington, just like the rest of them. Now Mabel was called Granny Van Pelt, and because that was a mouthful for small children, eventually just Granny Van.

The stock market crashed on October 24, 1929, but Mabel didn't find out until a few days later. She didn't have stocks or a bank account of her own, but it was in the papers and everyone seemed to be making a big deal about it, so Jim explained it to her. Around that same time, Mr. Fulton went and died and for some reason transferred the waterworks to Jim. They had to move out there, so they gave the house to Irene and her husband for $800. They sure were happy about that, right in the middle of having no money.

Now Mabel lived on the outskirts of town, the sound of that water near constant. Nothing much changed except for the location and the fact that people kept coming to live with them. Gene was born at their house. Shirley Collin was born at their house. Jim's mother came to live with them after her husband died and she couldn't stay with Addie on account of they're both so ornery. She'd get to crabbing when the kids would make any bit of noise. She died at their house too, which seemed rude to Mabel though she didn't say so. And then Eva, Roy and little Charles came up the road with a suitcase.

> *"She come in and cried and said, Well you know I'm going to have another one before long. Roy's been out of work for quite awhile and we didn't know where to go, only here and the restaurant."*

Then Helen and Bettie were born at their house. So now Mabel got up earlier and made more breakfasts and lunches. And so it went. Cooking, cleaning, birthing and dying. And in the hidden minutes, the thread went up and down, up and down. We hear tell that she fed people that were passing through leftovers out the back door, and that she gave a "colored family" a place to stay for the night. When the neighbors complained, Mabel said, "Well it ain't going to rub off on the sheets." This might have happened, or not.

> *I am fairly certain she quilted on a frame. No idea about the thimble. I just remember seeing her quilt set up in a downstairs bedroom. I am not sure about grandma, but I do know that Grandpa Van was openly not accepting of Black people. There is no way Grandpa Van would've allowed Black people to spend the night and it just doesn't fit with it happening at Clarence and Irene's house either. Where did that story come from?*

Even that far out of town, Mabel might of heard about the Marion county lynching, just 26 miles down the road.

> *IMAGE: Black and white image of the lynching of Thomas Shipp and Abram Smith in front of a large and merry crowd. The photograph reads: "Marion, Ind, Aug. 7, 1930"*

She might have been there.

She might have been part of the crowd.

Or she might have intervened.

> *J. Thomas Shipp and Abraham S. Smith were African-American men who were murdered in a spectacle lynching by a group of thousands on August 7, 1930, in Marion, Indiana. They were taken from jail cells, beaten, and hanged from a tree in the county courthouse square. They had been arrested that night as suspects in a robbery, murder and rape case. A third African-American suspect, 16-year-old James Cameron, had also been arrested and narrowly escaped being killed by the mob; an unknown woman and a local sports hero intervened, and he was returned to jail.*

Or not.

Anyway, it didn't affect her life much and five years later, Jim moved the family once more to Henry Street where Mable stayed for the next 35 years.

> *Image: Two story white clad house, Henry St. Huntington, IN.*

War is bad for people but good for the economy, and the Second World War sure helped out and got most people back on their feet. Mabel didn't admit it, but she was happier during the war, everyone out of the house and time on her side again. She put the flag back in her garden. Oh she knew it was bad so she never mentioned it, but somehow against all odds, that war made things a little easier. It wasn't until after it ended that the deaths really started. Eva, then Mabel's father, then John, and Bill. Somewhere in there the Korean war and then Vietnam. And then Jim died at a hospital in Ft. Wayne and she wasn't there. A few hours later, Mabel's great-granddaughter Dawn Elizabeth Wood was born at a different hospital just a couple hours south. Mabel thought it was simpler when everyone was born and died at home. More clean up though. Then Ivan died, then Orville. As fast as they'd been born it seemed to Mabel. Time is funny like that, up and down, up and down.

Mabel finally exercised her right to vote in 1962 when her son Marion was elected Sheriff of Huntington, still a notorious sun-down town. Mabel thought she couldn't have been more proud.

IMAGE: Van Pelt for Sheriff needle cover

IMAGE: Huntington County Sheriff's Department. Pictured L to R: Sheriff Marion Van Pelt, Deputy Donald Shideler, and Deputy Rex Huffman with a patrol car, 1963 Mercury Monterey S-55 Breezeway. The entire department consisted of a Sheriff and two Deputies. The Matron was Mrs. Van Pelt, Marion's mother. Sheriff Van Pelt served Huntington County from 1962-1970.

But then Mabel became the jail's matron and cook. Her cooking became famously good and men would commit small crimes for a good meal. She was more proud of that than anything.

"Many of the fellas said they'd do something wrong just to get to sent to jail because that cook down there, oh, she cooks the best meals and I said, well, whenever they sent men over here from Wabash, they'd call us, and would you take four or five, and they'd had an overflow. And we'd take 'em. They'd say to our boys, why it's a good thing you got a cook like this. If you's over to Wabash, you wouldn't have meals like you get here. And they'd tell us about it. And the police would come in and say, I send them down here to punish 'em, not to feed 'em like you're feeding 'em! And I said, well, they's human. They's human. And my land, they'd come and say, well I send 'em to punish 'em, and they're enjoying it! Oh I got bawled out lots of times 'cuz I sent 'em such meals. But they's human."

It wasn't too long after that Mabel flew in an airplane for the first time. Her grandson Jim escorted her onto the plane, sat her close up to the front.

"Now you're alright" he said. "And grandma, I forgot to tell you, you'll hear a noise. Don't get scared. It's them closing the wheels up underneath, and you might think something is wrong, and I want to tell you it's alright. I can just shut my eyes and see the skies, how we go above the clouds. Just think, come here in a covered wagon, traveling over rock and everything, and had all different kind of cars, most kinds, and then to end up in an airplane."

She liked it. Yes, she sure did like to fly. But she liked being on the ground too. Now cleaned and cooked for prisoners and family alike. When Mabel's grandsons couldn't agree on whether lemon meringue or chocolate pie was best, Mabel had two ovens put in on the back porch so she could bake a pie for each of them. She'd save the leftovers for the prisoners – nothing went to waste. They liked the lemon pie best in the summer, cool on their tongues in the sweltering cell. And then she'd clean some more, and the needle and thread moved forward at even stretches. Pretty soon she finished a red and white Irish chain quilt and the kids ate popcorn on it while they watched the new television. That's only in pieces now but they all still recall it.

Sometime after all that, Mabel shattered her leg. She was the only one who was calm about the whole matter.

"They was gone that day, and when they come home that night, I had turned the television off and started out to get supper in a pail, and broke my leg. And they come in, and Marion hollered, and I said, "Don't get excited, Marion." I was all bloody. And he said, "What happened?!", and I said, "Now, nothing Marion, I just fell, and I've broke my leg." Because when I tried to crawl to the phone, my leg bent back and I had to straighten it and I couldn't get to the phone, just like an old lady. Blood all over my face. Oh, he had a fit."

With her leg up in slings and weights, Mabel started a double wedding ring quilt. She had a lot of healing to do so she made it full size. Worked on it now and then but after her leg got better and her arthritis got worse, she had to put it down more often than not. Then one day, she put it down and just never picked it up again.

When Mabel was 93 she broke her hip and that was it. Her quilt and some other things were packed away and some dear things were sold which made Mabel cross. She moved into an old people's home and now someone else cooked and cleaned. On Valentines day, Mabel's daughter died suddenly in the night. She didn't suffer at all, but Mabel sure did. She recalled it 4 years later in the nursing home, talking to her grandkids for the first time on a tape recorder.

"I couldn't hardly get over how awful it was. Just fell asleep without making a sound, with her husband reading to her from the paper and everything. Didn't hear a thing."

Not too long after that, Marion went. The people at the nursing home wanted her to go see him. They took her in a van, wheelchair and all, and she went in at 10 o'clock in the morning, touched his hands and face and...well she wouldn't have him suffering another three months of that for anything. If he couldn't get better, he's better off, that's what she said. He always wanted her to live to be a hundred. She just had three more years to go, but now that he'd gone, she could let that goal go on account of he wouldn't be there to see it.

"I said you're all mine. I can't have you much longer, but then I've had you this long and I'm proud of all of you."

Mabel Van Pelt died in Huntington, Indiana on December 26, 1984. Just like her father, she waited until after Christmas as was polite. She refused to spoil the holiday for the family. Less than a month later, Mabel watched the birth of her great-great granddaughter Heather Irene Jones on January 17, 1985 in Bloomington. She'd met the 2 older ones a few months back but not this one.

When she was 98, Mabel watched news about the Cold War on television, followed on its heels by the Gulf War. Later she heard about the World Trade Center and the Pentagon, the War in Afghanistan, the Iraq War, and so on. She wasn't sad to miss any of it – she'd seen enough war by that point and nothing much changed except whether or not she had to put a flag in her garden. It did seem like everything was speeding up though, the killing included.

When she was 135, Mabel was surprised when her great-great granddaughter pulled her old quilt top out of a plastic bag in a box in the upstairs bedroom. It had been messed with – red and blue squares added by machine and blocked off to make a straight edge. Not the way Mabel would've done it, but what can you do? She was glad to see it though and watched as her great-great-granddaughter picked up the thread. Saw her haul it over the

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ocean on an airplane, pick out the stitches, take out the polyester fill that was put in somewhere along the way and replace it with proper wool batting. Her stitches weren't neat – 8 stitches per inch is ideal – but she'd get there if she just keeps pecking at it. She leaned down to instruct, "A bent needle is a good thing, but a broke one is useless. The difference is tension."

At 137, Mabel heard her great-great granddaughter talking to some politician about a prisoner. She read a poem by the prisoner which Mabel thought was real pretty, about love, and nighttime, and being free.

At Last...Another Heartbeat

the silhouettes of their bond visible still at the last glow of the sun
they experience each other and the life of the night as it begins to stir
standing there in silence holding hands
no rush to go back inside
there is so much beauty and comfort in being in love and just being...
—amidst sounds of buzzing
chirps
crickets
the pleasant but irregular blowing of the wind
fireflies dancing in step with the light of the moon
how strange it is to become aware of another's heartbeat but forget one's own—
*finally love.**

* 'At Last...Another's Heartbeat,' Marcellus Khaliifah Williams, 2024.

Mabel remembered cooking in the jail and went to visit the man who wrote it. Watched what he ate for his last meal: chicken wings and tater tots. My lands, that's no meal! He's human after everything. She thought about making him a pie, but baking is remarkably difficult when you're dead. Plus lard is out of fashion in the stores these days.

There were lots of protests, letters and phone calls, but they went ahead with it. At this point, Mabel was no longer bothered by death, nor did she feel the need to look away. She watched as they draped white over his body, like a sacrifice, or a bride. Put a needle in his arm, some tubes. Mable thought that in a gun loving country such as this one, surely it'd be cheaper, faster, and more honest to just shoot him. But that'd make a god-awful mess. Mabel knew from experience that scrubbing out blood stains is a pain. Your hands get cold, and it's a sad waste of salt. Anyway, his feet twitched, like chickens do if you've ever seen 'em, then stilled. And that was that.

After he was done being killed, the man took the needles out of his arm, got up, and folded the sheet. And because both he and Mabel were now finally free, and because he and Mabel both knew not to waste good fabric, and because he and Mabel both knew that all of this is an American tradition, he gave the sheet to Mabel for her next quilt.

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WARSHIP

MAKING SENSE OF ETERNITY THROUGH TEXTILES

EVER LAVÉN

READING AS RITUAL: A METHODOLOGICAL NOTE

This text is not linear. It moves across material, memory, and ritual, by way of experimental methodology, theoretical reflection, and poetic fragments. In my research, material becomes a site of expression and transmission: performed in exhibited form, ritual practice, and language. The writing follows an approach where poetry becomes an agent in creating space for the symbolic, the felt, and the ambiguous—making meaning through rhythm, repetition, and return. The poems act as interfaces: offerings and responses that invite other ways of knowing. They are to be read as part of the inquiry[1] for pause, for attention, for resonance. A way of reflecting on how reading and writing carry responsibility: for the stories that are told, and for those left unspoken.

1 This poetic methodology is informed by the concept of "Poetry as Inquiry," as articulated in Sandra L. Faulkner, *Poetic Inquiry: Craft, Method and Practice* (Walnut Creek, CA: Left Coast Press, 2016).

The family relics in the root cellar
were a Bible, copper, and glass
And a virtue
to vacate commercial filth
TV is for stupid kids
So are tattoos—
and makeup
Everyone is an idiot.
Everything is rubbish.
Two shadows in the doorframe—
frown upon worldly vices
'Politics is for city folks'
because no one cares about birch anymore
Potatoes, sugar, and grains were their guns—
fermented—
in another system under pressure
'They were having sex in the church benches!'
Between two beer cans, my uncle tells me—
about the flesh on the pew made of pine
But in His name,
in His blood
flushed cheeks are forgiven

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Near the ceiling of the church's central aisle hangs a miniature ship. Suspended by rope and wire, built from wood, metal, and glass. It is painted with symbols and flags, rigged with sewing thread and hemp. Its sails are cut from linen and cotton. These votive ships are maritime offerings, given to the church by sailors and shipbuilders from coastal parishes, where seafaring was part of everyday life.[2] The votive ship is a material prayer for protection or gratitude for surviving a shipwreck. Its placement becomes an interface between the earthly and the spiritual. A ritual offering suspended between sea and sky. These craftworks carry a non-verbal knowledge, offering insight into the kinships and worldviews of past belief systems. Made by hand, re-enacted by the church, and witnessed by those who look up. To the ceiling, to the hull of a material devotion.

As someone who works with textiles as an artistic expression—in joining by thread, in sculpting and distorting, in revealing and concealing bodies and spaces—I think of material as an *interface*[3]: a threshold that invites transformation and the emergence of new knowledge. It is a site of contact where bodies, beliefs, histories, and materials interact and alter one another. In some ways, it functions as a liturgical device—the structure and form through which public worship is conducted: the formal ordering of readings, hymns, and ritual acts.[4] To me, liturgy is compelling in choreographing a community to actualise another dimension of spiritual life. It is not only a religious act, but also a system of communication of giving and receiving. It requires participation rather than passive observation, drawing the community into an active involvement through repeated and collective movements.

Crafted objects and totems often hold a distinct role in religious practice, shaping rituals, structuring spaces, and making spiritual experience tangible. For many years, I have been mesmerised by a specific one—the mysticism and ritual complexity

2 The word *votive* comes from the Latin *votum*, meaning vow or prayer. See Anders Piltz, *Kyrkorummets symboler* (Stockholm: Veritas Förlag, 2004).

3 The term *interface* is commonly defined as a point where two systems, subjects, or conditions meet and interact. In this context, it refers to a material threshold — a zone of relation where bodies, beliefs, and histories encounter one another. *See Merriam-Webster Dictionary*, "Interface," [online] https://www.merriam-webster.com/dictionary/interface [accessed 22 April 2025].

4 In traditional Christian liturgy, this structure reflects a reciprocal exchange: the congregation offers *sacrificium* (prayer, praise, confession), while God responds with sacramentum (grace, forgiveness, and the sacraments). See Carl Henrik Martling, *Liturgik: En introduktion*, 2nd rev. ed. (Stockholm: Verbum, 2006).

of the Shroud of Turin: a linen cloth bearing the image and bloodied traces of a crucified man. While some believe this cloth to be the authentic burial shroud of Jesus Christ, others interpret it primarily as a religious icon depicting his story rather than an original artefact.[5] Regardless of its authenticity, the Shroud remains deeply significant as a spiritual symbol and liturgical object central to Catholic devotional practice. It has been extensively studied, digitised, and reproduced, gaining new layers of meaning through modern visual technologies. Even in this transformation, it retains a profound spiritual resonance. Like the votive ships, the Shroud mediates between the material and the spiritual. Its ritual use and context enable the transmission of faith across generations without relying on written texts. It does not represent faith. It performs it—it is an interface.

In semiotic traditions, liturgy emerges as a survival strategy: not through language or sentence structure, but through repetition, form, and cultural memory.[6] The survival of meaning depends on more than rational communication. It relies on our capacity to create signs that can be intuitively understood and remembered, even after their original language has faded. For meaning to endure in this way, as with the Shroud of Turin, it is embedded in material form, in the ritual around it and sustained through acts of performance.

5 Shroud of Turin Education and Research Association, *The Shroud of Turin* [online], https://www.shroud.com [accessed 22 April 2025].

6 Thomas A. Sebeok argues that ritual functions as a semiotic strategy for transmitting cultural knowledge across time, particularly when linguistic systems are no longer accessible. Meaning, in this view, survives through performative and material signs rather than solely through written language. See Thomas A. Sebeok, *Pandora's Box: Essays in Semiotics and the Human Sciences* (New York: Springer, 1986).

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Velvet skin
Mother observes you
Her name is on a sticker—
caressing a white box
—'Here's your AD drops!'
Our chemical welfare,
in block letters—
that makes your bones thicker

Tender soles
Climbing the cupboard
My name has no sticker—
on a glass bottle
It tastes like God,
so I sneak a spoonful extra of—
Vitamin A—
to stay Alive
Vitamin D—
to Die,
in a country where the sun never shines

Dyed hair
Pleasant fragrance
of suburban gas stations—
Father is fueling up
—'Let go of the car window!—
Those fumes are bad for you!'
Glass slips shut,
I mutter:
'...my bones were forged from the steel
of this country'

In the community where I grew up, close to the archipelago, the rituals once surrounding votive ships had long been forgotten. By then, seafarers no longer feared shipwreck. Their sailing boats and yachts, with towering polyester and Dacron sails, remained mostly moored along the calm waters of Nacka. Linen sails, collective offerings, and rituals belonged to another era. Church attendance had dwindled to the occasional wedding or funeral. Over time, communal acts of devotion were replaced by civic duties and moral discipline shaped by state institutions.[7] With modernity, the body was no longer governed by religious morality but by measurable productivity, public health, and economic value.[8] The promise of salvation was transferred to systems of welfare and the market. The church couldn't save anyone from despair; capitalism would.

Religious belief gave way to a new liturgy: the rituals of consumption, self-improvement, and civic obedience. The height of the masts on the sailing yachts began to correlate with the measuring agencies of wealth and worth. Although I was raised in a self-described secular society, religion still found its way through subtle values and practices passed on by family and social routines. While my parents distanced themselves from their northern Swedish ties to Lutheran revival movements, diluted forms of those beliefs shaped my upbringing. I participated in several church-affiliated activities throughout my early childhood: I was placed in a church-run preschool group, joined the local scout movement, and sang in the church choir for many years. My paternal grandfather was a vicar. This presence of faith was never explicit, but it was formative. My experience within the church environment often gave me a sense of validation for my passion for making and the existential questions that came with being a young person. At the same time, I found myself provoked by the moral order of the Gospels and the expectation of surrender they implied.

7 This transformation began in the 16th century, during the reign of Gustav Vasa, who in 1527 initiated the Swedish Reformation. What started as a political and theological break from the Catholic Church gradually evolved into a cultural shift that redefined the relationship between faith, governance, and daily life. See Bengt Kristensson Uggla, *Katedralens hemlighet: Sekularisering och religiös övertygelse* (Stockholm: Verbum, 2024).

8 Michel Foucault describes the historical shift from sovereign power to biopolitical governance, where control over bodies is no longer enforced through religious authority but through institutions of health, productivity, and regulation. See Michel Foucault, *Society Must Be Defended: Lectures at the Collège de France 1975–76*, trans. David Macey (New York: Picador, 2003), 242–245.

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I chose not to go through with the confirmation.[9] Conflicted by the intentions behind religious concepts, I, like most people in my community over the last century, had let go of faith, too.

Yet something has continued to linger. In recent years, I've realised that what I seek is a form of confirmation, not as dogma, but as recognition. I am missing a context affirming my bond with materials and the desire to make meaning through them. And the longing has been tied to ritual and its meditative quality. The presence, attention, and participation of attending church once created. It became a space I needed, not for faith, but for the spirituality that matters can hold. In the repetition and stillness, thoughts were activated. As a child, I learned patience in the church benches, where waiting became a way of thinking. It was an artistic methodology of listening inwardly, attuning to my surroundings, and learning to respond.

The concerns that shape my work today have taken form in this tension between what I let go of and what I continue to long for. My ambivalence toward faith seems to mirror a broader shift in Swedish society, where secularisation may have distanced many from organised religion and the very idea of the spiritual. This estrangement could signify more than a decline in belief, and perhaps it reflects a more profound cultural discomfort with what lies beyond rational explanation. I've come to question whether this hesitation also shapes how we relate to nature, material presence, and the act of making. As a maker, I am drawn to the fulfilment, friction, and longing that arise in close relation to material—by staying with it, observing it, and responding to its transformations.

This process affirms a way of being: a mode of attention that sustains connection, orientation, and meaning. It is in this context that I, through my work with textiles, want to investigate how experiences that resist scientific measurement can still hold value, beyond language and representation, when recognised within structures of care and material engagement.

9 In the Church of Sweden, confirmation is a liturgical act in which the baptised individual affirms their faith before God and the congregation. The rite has developed into a shared celebration, reflecting a liturgical understanding that emphasises communal participation rather than clerical hierarchy. See Carl Henrik Martling, *Liturgik: En introduktion*, 2nd rev. ed. (Stockholm: Verbum, 2006), 147–149.

My reflections have led me to consider liturgy and ritual as methodological and epistemological frameworks for understanding. Approaching ritual not as a reenactment but as an inquiry has opened new pathways for research, material, embodied, and intuitive exploration. Where votive ships and their vows have faded from public memory, the Shroud of Turin continues to endure, preserved not through explanation but through affective, material, and symbolic resonance, as if still marking the hour someone was once draped in it, many centuries ago.

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Lit candles cast shadows on slit-eyed faces
smiles made from an ivory sink
This day, a clowder—
below ground down a side street,
I was born in this city
Paws and petals collapsed on the linen cloth
shop-bought florals—
we sacrificed them first
Because grace would not survive
one night—
in this city

Once, liminal creatures on pitched rooftops,
we criss-crossed on steel-green patina
We sang, we howled, we laughed up there
Clear skies kept the tiles warm—
for our night climbs
With clenched jaws and fresh-cut wounds—
out of every exhale,
we made figures out of smoke
This is how we learned to love ourselves:
our fur, our tails,
and this city

Now we've come down—stitched into shirts
we let go of our night vision
Just to be buried in a winter soil,
in a void, underneath—
this city

Grooming our suits, imprinting scent—
to tame our feline hearts
Rituals that we forgot,
a long time ago—
in this city

Tonight, we wear our coats again,
We rub our skin with cold, hard wax,
and paint facades in opaque brown—
because when it melts
The sheen reflects the blood-lights—
of this city

The evening had ended, but the ritual had not. I began to wonder when it had truly started, and where it might end. I had read my manifesto aloud: a call for presence, care, attention, and spirituality. Each person was given a box, a piece of silk, a needle, and a candle. The instructions were loose—left deliberately uncertain, an invitation rather than a command. People gathered around the pit, and one by one chose to offer something of themselves: what weighed on them, sweat, tears, or blood pressed into the silk. A circle took form. A movement began. Then a chant rose, a reverb from within—and no one stopped chanting until every offering had been made.

We lit the candles dipped in wax from the pit in the final moment. There was both loudness and silence at once. It became something I could not first name—a shared act already lived within them—a powerful and moving communion. But I felt we had built a warship—not of metal or wood, but of memory, attention, and movement. We were crossing into the following year, but also into another state of being. Regrets, sorrows, and tenderness had surfaced—traces of the past, not to be dissolved, but to remind us how history resists time. Your story is not behind you. It is what you carry, what carries you, and what makes us endure. Though sealed in silk, hardened in wax, with warmth and interaction, it will become buoyant again.

Over the weeks, the silk, infused with blood, saliva, sweat, and tears, was folded and hardened with beeswax into a dark red lump. I was waiting for a material response. The discipline I learned on the church bench. For a long while, the offering existed only as a vague silhouette. A carrier of inner residues. This ritual was never intended as—and could not be presented as—a spectacle or performance. The offerings became an intimate and collective body, absorbed into a materialised research. A tool for generating knowledge and responding to questions in my practice: liturgical (as structured ritual), agential (involving human and non-human forces), and ecological (situated within a web of relations). It insists on the ethical implications of material entanglement.[10] In participating in the ritual, we enter into a relationship

10 Karen Barad's theory of agential realism posits that matter is not passive but actively participates in meaning-making. Knowledge is not located in subjects or objects, but in the intra-action between them. This framework emphasises that all encounters — human and non-human — are ethically charged and situated within relational fields. See Karen Barad, *Meeting the Universe Halfway: Quantum Physics and the Entanglement of Matter and Meaning* (Durham: Duke University Press, 2007), 90–91, 132–136.

with one another, the materials, and the conditions that bind us. We share accountability.

Nothing in this exchange is neutral. The lump remained a research archive, and there was no impulse to tamper with it. Its form seemed to ask for stillness. Yet it was also a trace. And eventually, it led somewhere. One day, I encountered a photograph of textile fragments from the excavations at Birka. Distressed remnants of fabric, gathered into a formless lump—unmistakably part of a larger structure. I read that it had most likely belonged to a sailcloth. At that moment, I recognised it: this is where the ritual had begun. I saw the continuity I hadn't yet articulated. An ecology of images, relationships, and objects began to take shape: the Turin Shroud, the votive ships, the crumbled fabric from the seabed. Together, they allowed me to start sensing my questions. The warship was taking form.

The sail holds space. A sloop[11] reveals an arrangement of cloth in sharply defined shapes. Angles, lines, and edges pulled into tension. In my studio, similar forms had begun to appear. Over the years, I had gathered fabrics: cottons, silks, linens—some metallised, coarse, some luminous. They were fragments without purpose then, but now they gathered into something that resembled a structure. A piece from a fabric market in Paris became the jib. A linen panel formed the mainsail. The scraps were too small for larger work and took the shape of a topsail. That transformation so often begins with a sail, which is perhaps no coincidence. At the beginning of stories, in myths, and in the Bible, the sail is raised before the journey starts towards the unknown. To make a sail is to engage with this tradition of departure: carrying something forward through uncertainty, toward a new kind of knowledge.

In tracing the history of sailcloth, I find myself moving between past and present. I am visiting Sjöhistoriska museet (The National Maritime Museum). I read manuals for sailmakers and books about the art of sailing. I browse sailing equipment stores. Sails and the textiles used in maritime culture are particularly interesting in how they offer a framework for understanding cloth beyond its relationship to the body, particularly in spiritual

11 A sloop is a single-masted vessel with a fore-and-aft sail plan, known for its balance, efficiency, and responsiveness. See Thomas Whidden and Mark Levitt, *The Art and Science of Sails* (Mystic: Mystic Seaport Museum, 2016), 52.

contexts. Even though the development of seafaring and shipbuilding relied on highly skilled craftsmanship, deep knowledge of materials, and the ability to read weather and wind, our understanding of early maritime life remains limited. What we know about religious practices in pre-Christian times is fragmentary and often speculative. Organic materials rarely survive in soil due to decomposition. In contrast, waterlogged environments, where oxygen is absent, have enabled the preservation of certain organic remains. Fragments of ship timbers and lumps of tarred fabric embedded in lakebeds. These remnants provide limited yet meaningful insight into the vital role of boats and sails in the everyday lives of early seafaring communities. Excavated textiles from around Scandinavia reveal that sails were constructed from panels of wool, hemp, and linen, carefully joined together for strength.[12] Images of ships carved into runestones may offer insight into the shapes and proportions of sails, even if they are only scaled, symbolic, or imagined representations of actual vessels. These remains provide glimpses rather than certainties. Archaeology helps to fill some of the gaps in our knowledge, adding texture to the past. But we must also attend to what has not been preserved. To what is excluded, overlooked, or decomposed. Whose stories are told? And what forms of knowledge remain unrecorded?

12 Lars Hanson et al., *Birkas skepp: Vikingatid på Östersjön* (Stockholm: Statens historiska museer, 2018), 84–89.

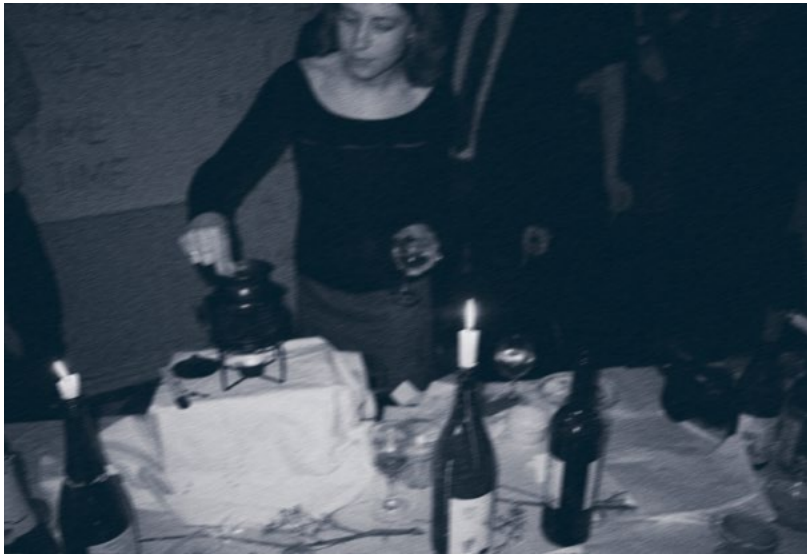
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My pale white scalp—
said something about the inside of my mouth,
a tongue rolled in salted bitumen
Scaled with slag, gravel and stone
My brother called it a serpent
I had learned it was shaped by the circular line
Carved out of timber,
and sticky with oats and potatoes
'Pärer',my grandfather smiled,
making dumplings from them,
with pig blood and wheat
I wondered how pears could grow underground
in the north—
when they hung from trees
in the south

This summer, I licked the tears of the tundra
and I set sail on the blood-stained bark
of my ancestors—
In the same cold springs where they wept for Betula—
my tongue rested softly,
against milk teeth
Here, my great-grandfather worked the woods every day
until the forest kept him
Some said a log crushed him—
his head and his tongue
The children packed what they could,
afraid the forest would take them too

At midnight in Karesuando,
my father took me to the graveyard
At this latitude death couldn't reach us
I lay in his lap, drawing my dreams—
onto skies of orange paper sheets
Pappa, I asked—
will you tell me about Betula?
—'He was a man tall as a spruce,
with golden bowls for hands—
feeding wanderers, bootleggers, and hunchbacks
Men came from Finland, Japan, and Romania
Betula learned all his lovers' tongues
In these northern woods,
they whispered—
that he was Medusa'

A sail has no true backside. The sails are given shape to catch and respond to the wind. Therefore, both sides of the fabric are equally necessary for the boat to perform. To tack, to reach, to run. When the wind comes from behind, the sail's shape matters less. But in crosswinds or when heading upwind, the form of the sails becomes crucial. The most important condition is that wind can flow unobstructed across the leeward side. This pressure differential, the subtle undercurrent, propels the ship forward. Animating the sail through its aerodynamic properties.[13] A boat cannot sail directly into the wind and must move at an angle. It advances by tacking, back and forth, to reach its destination. In this non-linear motion, the sail enacts a different sense of time. The past and the future are not separate; they are part of what it means to move forward. Progress becomes a matter of relation. An ethical matter. Between material, wind, and human hands, the sail flickers through the air, catching and releasing, listening to both sides.[14]

The sail can be seen as an expression of human endeavour —a desire for movement, exploration, and the pursuit of distant horizons. Yet the sailcloth is also a veil for darkness. Woven into its fabric are histories of colonial conquest: sails that carried not only goods and knowledge, but also terror, erasure, and exploitation. Like Joseph Conrad's voyage into *Heart of Darkness*, the sailcloth conceals unsettling truths beneath the surface of civilisation. The semi-fictional journey of Charles Marlow mirrors historical ones, revealing the moral fractures of imperialism and its aesthetic disguises. "There is a taint of death," Marlow says, "a flavour of mortality in lies."[15] The sail is complicit, and so are we. Marlow recognises his role in the unfolding violence, yet his course remains unchanged. We, too, are entangled in the legacy: in the narratives we construct, the knowledge we pursue, and the images we choose to reproduce. This accountability extends beyond content. It reaches into form: into how we transmit, how we preserve, and how we choose to respond. This complicity is not only visual or literary; It is also material.

13 Thomas Whidden and Mark Levitt, *The Art and Science of Sails* (Mystic, CT: Mystic Seaport Museum, 2016).

14 Karen Barad, Meeting the Universe Halfway: *Quantum Physics and the Entanglement of Matter and Meaning* (Durham: Duke University Press, 2007).

15 Joseph Conrad, *Heart of Darkness* (Stockholm: Modernista, 2024; first published 1899).

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Throughout colonial history, sounds, gestures, and textiles were not erased but redirected—enfolded into new regimes of meaning. Religious powers, particularly through *syncretism*[16], absorbed indigenous cosmologies into Christian frameworks. Conversion did not always require destruction; only recontextualization was necessary. The votive ship is also an example of syncretism. Christian narratives were adapted to local maritime contexts in the Gospel story of *Jesus calming the storm at sea*. For seafarers, this miracle was more than a metaphor—it affirmed that the divine could master the elements. A theme reenacted through their votive offerings. Each version of the story, in *Mark, Matthew*, and *Luke*, shifts subtly depending on its audience.[17] *Mark's* emphasis on fear and faithlessness resonated especially with sailors facing sudden tempests. Viewed through a folkloristic lens, the *Calming of the Sea* becomes a cultural code, shaped by collective fear and the human longing for safety. At once reassuring and unsettling.

The undercurrents of my religious heritage have cultivated both ambivalence and curiosity toward the symbolic power of faith. It didn't make me a Christian, but it left a lasting impression—of respect and awe—and I remain drawn to how belief moves people, binds communities, and sustains material attention. A sensitivity to, and comfort with, the rituals, structures, and atmospheres that spirituality inhabits continues to inform my practice.

Through a posthuman mindset, I approach contemporary syncretism and semiotic connection as methods inherited from religious techniques—ways of addressing the immaterial through material means. Textile becomes my interface: a site for presence and accountability, where making becomes a meeting point for understanding temporalities beyond the chronological timeline. Spiritual practices can evoke a sense of wonder, expanding our perception of existence through attentiveness, repetition, and material engagement. Within them, ritual becomes a mode of inquiry. It is not grounded in theology but in participation—a method of survival. Ritual resists causal structures in favour of

16 Syncretism is not a neutral blending of beliefs, but a dynamic process shaped by asymmetries of power. It emerges through historical encounters such as colonisation and missionisation, where subordinated groups adopt, resist, and transform imposed systems while preserving elements of their own. See Charles Stewart, 'Syncretism and its Synonyms: Reflections on Cultural Mixture', *Diacritics*, 29(3) (1999), 40–43.

17 The calming of the storm appears in Mark 4:35–41; Matthew 8:23–27; and Luke 8:22–25. See *The Holy Bible*, New Revised Standard Version (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1989).

open processes: spaces for asking and responding to questions without predetermined answers. It is a way of thinking through making and reflecting on what it means to know and be in the world. It becomes a form of ontological inquiry when addressing the symbolic, the unmeasurable, and the unknown.

Within this project, artistic research reveals itself as a vital mode of inquiry that engages with phenomena beyond the grasp of conventional science, yet which remain deeply real: felt, lived, and materially present. It reveals the limits of science—in what it measures, and in what it omits. Past and future are entangled in matter—textiles make this entanglement tangible. For artists and makers, meaning rarely resides in technique or aesthetics alone. Our work becomes a channel for reflection and reverence. Fabric is not a passive surface, but a site where time, memory, and presence converge. It is a religious technology in its own right—a communicative system articulated through folds. This material engagement demands responsibility: to make is to respond to histories, matter, and their ongoing transformations.

In the absence of traditional spirituality, sustaining meaningful relations with the more-than-human world may depend on crafting new forms of significance by adapting techniques and communicative practices that have long carried reverence. In this context, ritual became a warship, and the sailcloths—offerings, interfaces, and agents. They are not simply artworks, but material witnesses: shaped through a ritual-based methodology where meaning surfaced slowly, through acts of care, making, and sensing. These textiles carry traces of memory and devotion. They are not instructions or representations, but invitations to encounter meaning through material intelligence. They listen and respond to the wind, to forces unseen. They are not static, but shaped by movement: interfaces between material and immaterial, presence and absence, and what might be.

Skidbladner (Skíðblaðnir) is a Norse mythology warship crafted by dwarves and given to Freyr, the god of fertility, prosperity, and good harvests. It was so skillfully crafted that the ship needed no rowing; its sails always caught a favourable wind. It could be folded like a cloth and carried in a pocket when not used.

Skíðblaðnir heitir skip Freys,
hann er beztr skipa ok mest ger.
Hann hefir svá góðan byr,
þá er segl er dregit,
hvar sem fara skal,
ok er hann gert svá hagliga,
at hann mátt saman leggja sem dúk
ok hafa í pung sér.[18]

18 Snorri Sturluson describes Skíðblaðnir in *Gylfaginning* as such: "Skíðblaðnir is the name of Freyr's ship. It is the best of all ships and the most finely made. It always has a favourable wind as soon as the sail is hoisted, wherever it is to go. And it is made with such craftsmanship that it can be folded up like a cloth and carried in a pouch." See Snorri Sturluson, *Edda*, trans. and ed. Anthony Faulkes (London: Everyman, 1987), 47.



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WHAT IS NOT QUOTED BUT STILL THERE

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UNBOXING FIBERS

HOW TO UNRAVEL THE DESIRE OF THE HIDDEN AND OBSCURED

LISA RYDELL

LISA RYDELL
UNBOXING FIBERS
HOW TO UNRAVEL THE DESIRE OF THE HIDDEN AND OBSCURED

UNRAVEL

> Seeing all these questions emerging on paper, I have the impression (...) that I have never had any other subject: basically, paper, paper, paper.[1]

You see a box. A container of something hidden. It is brown and made of cardboard with stapled corners. A silk white belt is wrapped around the box, is it a weave? You may want to touch it, to feel and to categorize the material. If you are into textiles, maybe your mind goes through a list of possibilities: cotton, linen, ramie, wool, silk, paper. A text is printed on the front lid: a headline, a subtitle, a name. If you are interested in typography, you might know the font. It was made by women, though as often, attributed to men. You now may wonder what is inside the box. Your imagination is engaged.

You
desire
to
unbox
it.

The fact is that though paper is a non-living object, it is made of pulp containing different kinds of bacteria. Japanese traditional handmade paper, *washi*, is made of the long inner fibers of plants, which are living elements. The strongest and most widely used is *kozo*, the inner bark of the mulberry tree,[2] where each variety of kozo has its unique character and life. In 2014, I received a grant to visit Echizen, a small village located in the Fukui Prefecture on the mid-west coast of Japan. The area is specialized in washi making with a craft tradition and history going back 1500 years. I stayed in a Shinto temple[3] by myself, except for a spider – big as a miso bowl, and a monkey eating kaki fruit on the roof, for three weeks. Every day in the morning I rode a bike to *Udatsu Paper & Craft Museum,* trying to learn the process of making kozo washi.

1 Jacques Derrida, *Paper Machine* (2005) From chapter 5 "Paper or Me, You Know (New Speculations on a Luxury of the Poor)", (Stanford: Stanford University Press), 41.

2 Susan J. Byrd, *A Song of Praise for Shifu: Shifu Sanka*, (Michigan: The Legacy Press, 2013), 24.

3 Shinto is viewed as the indigenous religion of Japan. Kuroda Toshio, et.al. *Shinto in the History of Japanese Religion.* The Journal of Japanese Studies, Vol. 7, No. 1, (Winter, 1981), pp. 1–21. (University of California Press), 4. https://www.jstor.org/stable/132163 (Accessed March 2025).



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Initially, this artistic research project aimed to explore wrapping, packaging, and the philosophy of giving in Japanese and contemporary papercraft – unfolding the feelings and emotions connected to the act of giving and to the creation of a carefully wrapped and designed package, box, or book object, as situated within my contemporary interdisciplinary practice.

> What is the use of a package if it shows no feeling?[4]

During the work on this project, my initial aim remained, though it took an unexpected turn. By coincidence, I found *shifu*: a traditional Japanese craft where cloth is woven with handmade paper thread either in the warp, weft, or in both.[5] Even though shifu belongs to a field (textiles) I am not familiar with in practice, it was a logic step to take and attractive choice to make; to discover and explore the craft. An uncanny tension between belonging and not belonging, provided creative energy.

The philosophy, method, and technique correlated with the research approach: *How to unravel the desire of the hidden and obscured*. In historic shifu cloth, traces of handwriting and ink would appear irregularly like hidden messages, due to the reuse of old note and account books made of washi.[6] Gradually, I started exploring and attempting to understand the craft alongside the original intention.

> Consider everything an experiment.[7]

Basically, paper, paper, paper.

4 Hideyuki Oka, *How to wrap five eggs*, (Boulder: Weatherhill, 2008), 138.

5 Hiroko Karuno, "*Shifu: A Traditional Paper Textile of Japan*". Textile Society of America Symposium. Proceedings. 977. (2016), 254.

6 Ibid., 253.

7 Sister Corita Kent, Rule number 4 from "Ten rules". Written for a class Sister Corita Kent taught at the Immaculate Heart College Art Department, Los Angeles, California, (1967–1968) https://www.corita.org/tenrules (Accessed March 5 2025).



Kozo mulberry fibers are being rinsed to remove impurities. © Lisa Rydell

UNFOLD

What makes the unavailable and hidden desirable? The process of opening a package normally involves the following sequence: receiving and beholding the package, which invites us to open it; the act of opening, which engages our bodily movements; and exposing the content, which were initially hidden, either entirely or partially, from our view and touch. In short, as author Yuriko Saito describes, the experience is guided by the allure of what is hidden or obscured.[8] In ancient Japanese culture, the image of the moon hidden behind clouds or a landscape shrouded in mist, symbolized beauty and the aesthetics of concealment.[9] When the moon is obscured, we feel a sense of longing and anticipation, leading our imagination to play with the image of the hidden object. I enjoy watching the moon. Its mystery quietly stimulates the imagination. To engage these emotions and anticipation, "(...) the hidden artifact or object must be believed to be something positive or worth exposing. Thus, this positive experience that derives from concealment and obscurity is dependent upon the possibility of uncovering the wrapping and having access to the object of longing." In contrast, when an object is fully revealed, our emotional and imaginative capacities are less engaged.[10] This concept of aesthetics, imagination, and nature is also articulated by Kant as *the judgment of the sublime*. "For the sublime, in the strict sense of the word, cannot be contained in any sensuous form, but rather concerns ideas of reason, which, although no adequate presentation of them is possible, may excited and called into the mind by that very inadequacy itself which does admit of sensuous presentation."[11]

In a pilot research study called, *The Allure of the Hidden: How product unveiling confers value*,[12] the researchers examine the relationship between packaging design, unveiling, and value. While the study centers on the product from a marketing and consumer perspective, this research project examines the desire to reveal

8 Yuriko Saito, *Japanese Aesthetics of Packaging*,The Journal of Aesthetics and Art Criticism, Vol. 57, No. 2, Aesthetics and Popular Culture. pp. 257–265, (1999), 257.

9 Ibid., 258.

10 Ibid., 257.

11 Immanuel Kant, *Kritik av omdömeskraften*. (Stockholm: Thales, 1790, 2003) §23, sec 245.

12 Vanessa M. Patrick, et. al. *The allure of the hidden: How product unveiling confers value*. International Journal of Research in Marketing, Volume 34, Issue 2, pp 430–441, (2017), 430.

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hidden objects – wrapped and enclosed within a box – as well as the process of creating them at the intersection of craft and graphic design, with attention to the implications of a capitalist market. However, the study presents interesting empirical results related to human behavior and connects to Kant's and Saito's theories on imagination and unveiling. It defines "uncovering" as an embodied act in which a protective covering is removed from a hidden object. The conclusions indicate that "packaging that encourages unveiling (...) – enhances the perceived value of the product compared to other forms of product revelation."[13] Rosi Braidotti emphasizes that contemporary society is obsessed with all things "new," which disrupts our social structures and modes of exchange.[14] What if the act of folding, covering, and unveiling an object, perhaps even an object that is not tangible, serves as a form of resistance to capitalism and globalization? This could be a rejection of the "new technologies, new economy, new lifestyles, new generations of both human and technological gadgets, new wars, and new weapons," along with a complete social rejection of change and transformation.[15] Can the act of packaging be a way to manifest the love of the mysterious?

Gifts can act as agents of individual transformation and sometimes, the gift itself initiates this change.[16] What if the act of creating a package, a box, or a gift, is the gift itself? This raises the question of that the outside – as artifact and as act – is the actual inside? What if the process of opening an object, as well as the reverse actions of packaging, wrapping, boxing, and covering, represent embodied transformations? Could these actions be likened to what Braidotti refers to as transpositions – as a scientific theory that emphasizes the role of creative insight in fostering different, alternative ways of knowing?[17] What happens if this theory is adapted into the creative practice, and the ideas are

13 Ibid.

14 Rosi Braidotti, "Transformations". In M. Schwab (Ed.), *Transpositions: Aesthetico-Epistemic Opertors in Artistic Research*, edited by Michael Schwab, pp. 23–32, (Leuven University Press, 2018), 24. JSTOR, http://www.jstor.org/stable/j.ctv4s7k96.4. (Accessed 5 March 2025).

15 Ibid.

16 Lewis Hyde, *Some Food We Could Not Eat: Gift Exchange and the Imagination*, The Kenyon Review, New Series, Vol. 1, No. 4, pp. 32–60, (1979), 33.

17 Braidotti, "Transformations", 27.



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implemented as critical tools and methods in the artistic practice? (See next chapter UNVEIL.) I believe that focusing only on the "object" can be problematic. If we shift our perspective from focusing on objects to considering the act itself, could this help us move away from the objects to which contemporary society is so compulsively attached? "Object thinking"[18] leads us further away from understanding the true nature of the world. In his book *Thinking Like a Plant: A Living Science for Life*, author Craig Holdrege suggests, "The plant can teach us to look with the eyes of process into the world." By adopting this perspective, we could become more adaptable in our thoughts and work, responding flexibly to varying circumstances and conditions.[19] In this research project, the mulberry tree with its kozo bark serves as the "plant" and guiding agent, directing the process and embodied actions forward.

In the beginning of this research project, I interviewed Max Ahrent, assistant curator at Arkdes Stockholm, with the intention to unfold the concept of *unboxing*, that to my observations, has become a cultural phenomenon in recent years. Unboxing involves watching someone carefully open and reveal an unsealed, often "rare" object. The movements are typically slow and deliberate, reflecting a sense of respect and care for the item being unveiled. This practice can be seen as a blend of performance, lecture, and show-and-tell. (See also *ASMR at the museum*/ V&A Museum London, *Unboxing the Collection*/The Crafts Council London).[20] It engages the senses of curiosity and imagination, allowing the audience to be both active and passive simultaneously. During a physical unboxing event or performance, viewers have the option to ask questions, be close to the performer, and closely observe, listen, and engage with the experience, or they can choose to remain silent and simply watch. In the permanent collection at ArkDes, there is a space called *Unboxing* – a room within a room – where a curator becomes an *unboxing performer*, daily unpacking and revealing folders filled with projects, architectural drawings, and archival images. Each act of

18 Craig Holdrege, *Thinking Like a Plant: A Living Science for Life* (Great Barrington: Lindisfarne Books, 2013), 2.

19 Ibid., 118.

20 V&A, n.d. https://www.vam.ac.uk/articles/asmr-at-the-museum Crafts Council, n.d. https://www.craftscouncil.org.uk/about/collections/unboxing-the-collection (Accessed Nov 5 2024).

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unveiling transforms the archival material into a living encounter, where what was hidden is revealed. Max Ahrent describes it as a kind of performance, a bit of a mystery in the fact that the visitor comes to the space and discovers the material together with the curators. The purpose of the *Unboxing* project is to convey the collection and conduct research, deepening the material in complement to the collective exhibition, while also sharing what is typically considered secret with the audience. The act of unboxing allows a barrier to be removed.

Drawing on the theories and philosophies of Kant, Saito, Oka, Hyde, Patrick, and others, I believe this is an example of a contemporary need for *unveiling*. It represents an act of mystery embodied in both aesthetic and physical forms, uncovering the object of desire. Maybe as a reaction towards electronic media? This concept is related to Lacan's *objet (petit) a*, representing an *object of desire* that can – on the opposite – not be attained, which evokes emotions of both anxiety and the promise of pleasure.[21] The act of unboxing reveals not only the object of desire but also the performance of the act itself.

INFLUENTIAL AND PERSONAL INSPIRATIONAL MARKERS WITHIN ARTISTS' BOOKS

The book, as a creative and artistic medium, challenges our imagination. Artists' books represent an art form that manifests in visual, verbal, literal, and metaphorical ways. They are essential in their engagement with physical, material, and conceptual aspects, as well as in the production of meaning.[22] Dieter Roth is one of my favourite artist: his tactile and visual creations, are one of a kind. Roth was a highly influential artist in concrete art during the late 1950s and early 1960s,[23] particularly known for his radical interdisciplinary experiments with book design and publishing formats and he is considered as one of the most significant figures in the field of artists' books. One of his notable series, simply titled *books* (1958–64), contain no text, images, or bindings, and with no set orientation or sequence. Instead,

21 David Macey, objet (petit) a. In *The Penguin Dictionary of Critical Theory*, (London: Penguin Books, 2001), 280.

22 Johanna, Drucker, *The Century of Artists' Books* (New York City: Granary Books, 2007), 359.

23 MoMa, n.d, MoMa. https://www.moma.org/interactives/exhibitions/2013/dieter_roth/category_works/concrete/index.html (Accessed April 17 2025).

the books are brought to life through the actions and imagination of the reader.[24]

The Japanese artist Mieko Shiomi was a key figure in the development of the Fluxus Movement and a member of the radical music collective Group Ongaku in Japan during the early 1960s. Her artwork, *Endless Box* (1963–64) occupies a unique space within the realm of artists' books, as well as book objects and multiples.[25] The box is made of wood, containing 34 paper boxes of smaller and smaller sizes, wrapped in sheer transparent silk fabric. Although I have only experienced this artwork through images, I can envision how the box embodies a meditative approach to craft. Each paper sheet is transformed into folded boxes, and the act of opening the box reveals hidden surprises, creating a sense of anticipation and engaging the imagination. As Shiomi describes her process in creating *Endless Box*:

> I was thinking about transparent music, (. . .) I emptied my mind, and what came into it was an image of the origami boxes I used to make as a child. No matter how many boxes you opened, there would always be a slightly smaller one inside, and each time you opened a box, it was as if you were entering yet another, deeper layer of time. (. . .) [I] selected paper with the pliability, tension, and strength required for folding, in a white that sometimes appeared tinged with violet, depending on how the light struck it.[26]

Basically, paper, paper, paper.

24 Ibid.

25 Fluxusmuseum, n.d. https://fluxusmuseum.org/mieko-shiomi/ (Accessed March 20 2025).

26 Ibid.

UNVEIL

In the initial practice-based studies, I experimented with various folding techniques to create a box. One early project, made in my studio in Stockholm in late September 2024, involved a roll box wrapped in crumpled paper to serve as a Furoshiki "everyday wrap." This Japanese tradition emphasizes the practice of reusing cloth to wrap items.[27] I used unbleached Japanese paper for the wrap and natural white paper for the box, collected from my archive. However, the wrapping broke during the process, leading me to reevaluate my approach.

Subsequently, I focused on making a sturdy cardboard box to encapsulate my research. Inspired by Joseph Beuys's artist's book and box, *BEUYS* (1967), I created a flat box design using unbleached greyboard paper donated by Norrbacka Tryckeri. Since I couldn't join the edges myself, I enlisted Norrmalms Kartongfabrik to craft three handmade boxes. They ended up in standard C5 format rather than the intended *BEUYS* box dimensions, though the outcome was to my satisfaction.

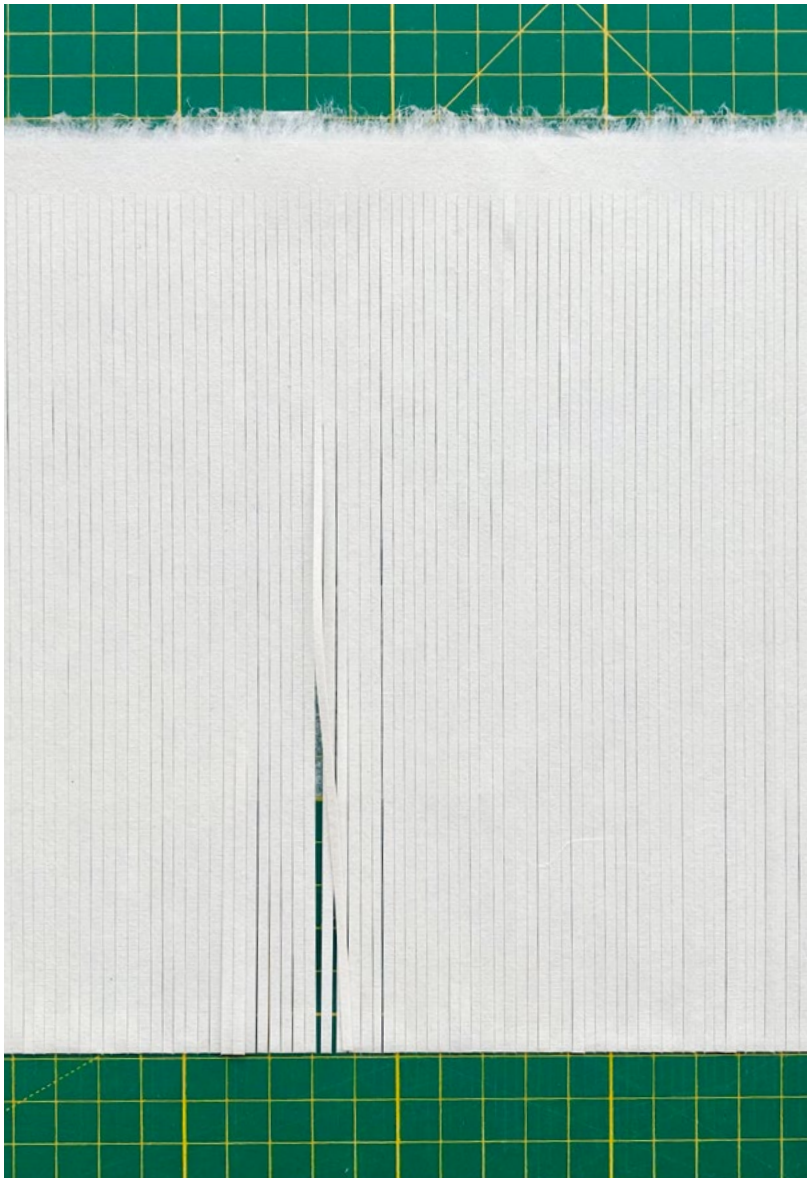
I frequently incorporate belts to wrap around the paper-related designs I make. This practice embodies a desire to conceal and protect the materials while inviting engagement and discovery. By shifting the focus from object-centered thinking prevalent in Western aesthetics,[28] we can explore the relationship between individuals and objects in a more nuanced way.

> Aesthetic engagement is an experience of aesthetic appreciation that transforms a physical juxtaposition into a social relationship in which a personal encounter takes place. It [the act] projects the aesthetic connection we can experience in the arts into our engagement with other people and with things, as well, turning our encounter with separate, impersonal objects into personal relationships.[29]

27 Tomoko Kakita, *Furoshiki: And the Japanese Art of Gift Wrapping* (Laurence King Publishing, 2021), 20.

28 Yuriko Saito, *Aesthetics of Care: Practice in everyday life*. (Bloomsbury Publishing Plc, 2023), 121.

29 Arnold Berleant, *Objects into Persons: The Way to Social Aesthetics*, Espes 6, no. 2, pp 9–18 (2017), 15.



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SHIFU STUDIES – ENGENDERING ALTERNATIVE VISIBLE AND HIDDEN WAYS OF KNOWING

Corita Kent's "Ten Rules," often attributed to John Cage, is displayed on the wall above my studio desk. These rules are not conventional guidelines; rather, they serve as a list of approaches that emphasize the importance of work ethics, intuition, and the integration of intellect (body and mind). They encourage an attitude of openness to all possibilities.

In October 2024, midway through my research, I reached out to Åsa Pärson, textile artist and senior lecturer in the Textile Department at Konstfack, whose expertise and vision offered invaluable guidance for my work. I asked if we could conduct an experimental workshop on shifu making, involving students from the Textiles program. She responded positively, and we were able to receive funding from Konstfack to purchase equipment such as weaving frames, fine Japanese washi paper, and textile printing colors.

The workshop was planned for late spring 2025, and, working towards this event (see next subchapter SHIFU WORKSHOP AT KONSTFACK), I began to explore the craft interdisciplinarily in the Konstfack Textile and Graphics workshops. I tried to ignore the uncanny feeling I experienced when entering the Textile workshop.

I chose to work with thicker kozo washi paper (46 grams) instead of the traditional thin washi (12–15 grams) used in Japanese shifu making, considering the limited time for the workshop and for my studies. I sourced the kozo paper from Konstnärernas Centralköp and also experimented with gampi paper, which has a warm white color but is more fragile. After acquiring the necessary tools – cutting knife, mat, and steel ruler – I folded the paper into "mountain folds"[30] and cut strips approximately 3 mm wide, leaving 2 cm uncut at the top. I placed the strips between damp towels and covered them with plastic wrap overnight. The next day, I stretched the paper and rolled it over a concrete surface for about ten minutes (*ito umi* or "thread rolling,"[31]) to roughen the strips for spinning. I paired and detangled two strips, creating

30 Byrd, *A Song of Praise for Shifu: Shifu Sanka*, 46.

31 Ibid., 58.

a long thread from both ends and then formed the characteristic shifu joint, or "paper seed",[32] by rolling the ends of the strips together into a continuous thread. As I spun, I found my own technique where I simultaneously twisted the joint before feeding it into the coil. Once spinning was complete, I used a special workshop tool to bundle the yarn into balls. The first stage of creating shifu yarn was now finished.

I experimented with creating threads from washi paper at different widths: 3 mm, 4 mm, and 6 mm. I found the 4 mm and 6 mm threads to be the most suitable for handweaving. Although the gampi washi had a beautiful color, it was too fragile, prompting me to use kozo washi instead. After these initial tests, I purchased a roll of Kozo Thick paper (42 grams) from Awagami Factory in Tokushima, Japan, great for allowing me to cut different sizes of the sheets.

I painted vibrant dots of fluorescent orange and wrote text from my work-in-progress-thesis before preparing the thread. While spinning, the painted dots made it challenging to achieve a smooth spin, but they added an experimental touch to the final woven piece, revealing random sections of color and text. This process aimed to mimic traditional shifu techniques that incorporate hidden text, and to add my contemporary expression from my situated practice.

To reconnect with weaving, I recalled my childhood experiences with my mother's loom. I set up a white warp of 50/50 silk and wool on a large Ashford frame measuring 43×78 cm and focused on understanding the materials and techniques.

For the final shifu weaves, which were intended to be wrapped around the artist's book boxes, I set up the warp to create straps with a width of 7.5 cm. I experimented with various weaves, including plain and Panama/basket weaves, and later used 100% silk yarn for an additional warp, incorporating different styles and bindings. It was very difficult to make a balanced weave, and I had to accept that the weaving was a tool, method and experiment, not a result. After completing the weaves, I cut and secured them with overhand knots, making them ready to wrap the boxes.

32 Ibid., 59.

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SHIFU WORKSHOP AT KONSTFACK

The workshop took place in mid-April 2025 in the weaving room at Konstfack, with first-year students in the Bachelor's Program in Textiles focusing on advanced weaving techniques. I encouraged a non-hierarchical environment where students were not merely an audience but co-participants in the creative process.[33] On the first day, I introduced the students to the history of shifu and its fundamental techniques. Each person received three sheets of Kozo Natural paper (46 grams, 52x43 cm) and could choose how to create their threads and designs. One student opted for delicate 2 mm strips, facing initial challenges but eventually succeeding. The others selected widths of 4 mm to 6 mm and creatively used textile screen printing inks – writing, painting, or keeping their sheets plain. At the end of day one, we stored the cut sheets in damp towels overnight.

Day two began with each student practicing the previously described "thread rolling," followed by "paper seed" making, and finally spinning, using either a manual spinning wheel or an Ashford electric spinner. By the end of the day, most students had produced 2–5 balls of thread and had begun weaving on their frames while experimenting with various techniques.

Day three focused on weaving, accompanied by coffee and tosca buns. In the afternoon, we held a group discussion, allowing each student to present their final pieces, methods, and aesthetic choices. Overall, the feedback was very positive, with the students expressing enthusiasm about exploring the craft and applying their newfound knowledge in future projects.

> Nothing is a mistake. There's no win and no fail, there's only make.[34]

33 Sheila Levrant de Bretteville, *Reputations: Sheila Levrant de Bretteville*. Interview by Ellen Lupton. (Eye Magazine, 1992) https://www.eyemagazine.com/feature/article/reputations-sheila-levrant-de-brettevile (Accessed February 19 2025).

34 Kent, *Rule number 6* from "Ten rules".

THE ACT OF TRANSPOSITION

The transition from graphic design and paper craft to textile craft can be understood as a transposition.[35] This process began when an action from one field was unexpectedly transferred to another, without disturbing the existing balance between the two. This shift created an indirect influence between the fields, marking a surprising move from graphic design to textile craft. The individual initiating this shift should ideally be an expert in the original field.[36] While I would not consider myself an expert, I have a deep understanding of—and love for—paper. As Esa Kirkkopelto explains, which aligns with my findings in this research: "... she foresees the possibility of transposition in relation to the other field, or recognizes it by accident or coincidence." This suggests that shifting focus from an initial goal to exploring a new craft can uncover new similarities and continuities between institutionally regulated disciplines. These connections are not based on fixed identities, but rather on the act of transposition itself.

> Within its new field, the transponent is at first a stranger, or even an intruder, but there is also something in it that is strangely familiar or unheimlich, and therefore also attractive.[37]

The craft of shifu serves as a tactile, interdisciplinary bridge, linking creative, practice-based work with theoretical discussions in this project. It represents a hybrid approach that grows out of the research,[38] interweaves theory and practice, and can be seen as a transpositional act. Through the process of unlearning and exploring my practice, I have ventured into unknown territories, shifting my approach to both my overall method and my engagement with a new craft and field. Despite my initial feeling

35 Esa Kirkkopelto, Abandoning Art in the Name of Art: Transpositional Logic in Artistic Research. In M. Schwab (Ed.), *Transpositions: Aesthetico-Epistemic Opertors in Artistic Research*, edited by Michael Schwab, pp. 33–40, (Leuven University Press, 2018), 36. http://www.jstor.org/stable/j.ctv4s7k96.5 (Accessed April 17 2025).

36 Ibid.

37 Ibid., 37.

38 Dirk Vis, *Research for People Who (Think They) Would Rather Create*. (Onomatopee Projects, 2023), 123.

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of being an intruder, by decoding my previous understanding and experimenting with new techniques and interdisciplinary methods, my approach to practice has expanded significantly. The process of undoing has revealed new possibilities for doing. It was important to me that this shift occurred "by coincidence" and in collaboration with people with whom I have an established working relationship. This support made me comfortable and encouraged me to explore, make mistakes, and embrace the process of "becoming research."[39] The final outcome, the artist's book, serves as a space for ideas to be freely developed and visualized. It is a physical form, crafted by my hands and others, that will continually be unboxed.

Basically, paper, paper, paper.

39 Irit Rogoff, *Becoming Research*, HEREAFTER, Sonic Acts Festival. 21–24 February 2019. https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=D3AcgQoGaSU

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THREADS OF THOUGHT AND MAKING

UNTANGLING THE REJECTED, GETTING ENTANGLED IN THE PROCESS

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UNTANGLING THE REJECTED, GETTING ENTANGLED IN THE PROCESS

ARTISTIC DIALOGUES

The starting point for my research has been rejected works that I have collected from other artists. My aim has been to give a voice to a silent process and to create a physical embodiment of a wordless dialogue. This research stems from a curiosity about what the creative process looks like for different people, and a desire to understand, and release, my own.

MY REQUEST

Would you be interested in joining me in an artistic dialogue? If you want to enter into an artistic conversation with me please allow me to have either:

1. An unfinished and abandoned art piece, in any state, that you are willing to relinquish control over entirely. I will interact with it and finish it using my own artistic voice.

OR

2. An unfinished piece that can form the beginning of an artistic conversation that you want to be an active part of. Then I will interact with the art piece artistically and return it to you, giving you an opportunity to continue or conclude the dialogue.

NOTES ON THE PROCESS

So far I have involved five artists in the project. I have worked on all available objects in parallel, though I often pause them for longer periods. The process has been very slow and tentative, so I have been grateful for the artistic “crop rotation”, allowing me to avoid getting stuck. The different “dialogues” have been documented and processed through photographs and writing. I have allowed the collaborations to occur almost by chance, asking inspiring people I happened to meet during the process, relying on serendipity.







Images from top to bottom:
Klara's cracked sculpture
Inger's rejected patchworks
Leif's performance leftovers
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BRICOLAGE

At the beginning of this research I looked back at my bachelor project which was titled "Autobiographical clothes" in which I used chance, random styling, and contorted self portraits as starting points for garments that were meant to be completely non-generic and totally personal. My position back in 2003 was that the only person I could portray with any certainty was myself. In this research project I open up the perspective and let myself meet someone else's creative world. I believe the voice in the original material can be amplified by meeting an unexpected shape or materiality. My research can be said to use the method of bricolage, a term coined by the anthropologist Claude Levi-Strauss in the 1960's.[1] The theory allows for the freedom of using what you have at hand, giving materials new meanings by taking them out otheir context and connecting them in new ways. Working in the wider craft field, this relieves me from having to find that pure, solid starting point, the raw material to dye, weave etc. I can start from scraps, trash, or even other works of art.

COLLABORATION

In my experience the creative journey goes through different phases, of which some are extremely precarious and vulnerable, at which times I don't wish to invite someone else into my head-space. When the input of another artist forms the starting point of my artistic process it seems I need a long time to myself, to be able to find my own voice and create a response. But I find some solace in reading that procrastination has been linked to creativity. Apparently a resistance to quickly finishing what you have started leads you to more ideas.[2]

Am I allowed to be this slow????![3]

I have to question whether the collaborations I started are really dialogues. Maybe a more apt description is that of call and response. Are they really collaborations or too one-sided? Are they one-sided to my "favour" or the original artist's? Since none of

1 Lévi-Strauss, Claude, *The savage mind*, University of Chicago Press, Chicago, 1966, p. 17.

2 Kyaga, Simon & Mattsson, Jonas, *Ekvilibrium: om sambandet mellan kreativitet och galenskap*, First edition, Natur & kultur, Stockholm, 2022, p. 139.

3 Excerpt from my notebook.



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the collaborators included in the project opted for option 2, where we would have passed the artwork between us until finished, I have in all five cases had the last word. However, in some of the objects I received the original artist's voice is very strong.

Helen Carnac co-founded a project in 1999 called Dialogue, which was both a collaboration in making and in conversation. Her motivations for collaborating are, among others: "a wish to be thrown into different or unexpected modes of thinking" and "the need to experience a friction or difference in practice".[4] That resonates with me. More than anything these collaborations have worked as catalysts for my own art. Collaboration in the form of acquiring an object, a starting point, attempts to remove the paralysis of facing a blank page.

BIRTH – A DIALOGUE WITH KLARA WIRSÉN SUCHOWIAK

I met the artist Klara Wirsén Suchowiak when she occupied a studio next to mine at WIP:Stockholm. In October 2023, she and a group called "Parts & Pieces" held an exhibition in Stockholm where she showed some sculptures cut from wood. They reminded me of some wooden shapes I had recently made, covered in appliqué. One day we walked together from the bus stop and I asked if she would make a shape for me to "dress". She told me she had a cracked sculpture that I could have. She hadn't been able to fix it and would be happy to see it go.

I had thought the sculpture was abstract, but when I brought it into my studio I saw that it was clearly figurative. A pregnant woman with a foetus hanging from the hollow shape inside her. The shape wasn't neutral at all, could not be treated as neutral. Its subject of motherhood had to be addressed. I put the sculpture aside, waiting for the strength to take on such a large subject. It would take me almost a year to get there. My first step to get started was to add cords and ribbons to give me something to sew into and to break the mildness of the color palette. The result felt surprisingly violent, like bondage. Was this any way to treat a pregnant woman? Why couldn't I just see it as a shape and do

4 Carnac, Helen: *Moving Things around... Collaboration and Dynamic Change* in Ravetz, Amanda, Kettle, Alice & Felcey, Helen: *Collaboration Through Craft*, London: Bloomsbury Academic, 2013, 33.

whatever I wanted with it? I tried to dress the "foetus". It felt sad. I was reminded of the tradition of Jizo statues in Japan, for protection of dead children and stillborn or aborted babies, was this going to be a story about that? It all felt cumbersome and heavy, both mentally and physically. It was so difficult to stitch around the shape while it was suspended in the center of the mother shape. I had to be very careful when moving it around, because there was already a crack where they were connected, and every time I tried to get into the tight spots, the crack would widen. Finally, of course, it broke completely. The baby and I were released from our constraints. It had been birthed and I had been released. Förlöst. En förlossning[5].

Suddenly, to me, the baby was no longer dead or in peril. It was alive. It could start to symbolise my own children since it could be turned head up, the way they had both been born. And since it was out of the belly it could start to show its personality in yet stronger colours, yet more complex shapes. I retied the cords and strings, the mother and child still completely entangled, but now the baby wasn't hung up inside the mother, but strapped to her on the outside. She will forever carry her child with her. I decided to keep the back of the baby unfinished, a tangle of loose ends. An unwritten page for all the difficult stories that exist at the dark side of motherhood.

BIRD FIGURE – A DIALOGUE WITH INGER BERGSTRÖM

In January of 2023 I went to listen to an artist talk that Inger Bergström held in her exhibition "Space floating through my eyes" at Konstakademien in Stockholm. She was exhibiting large works made in patchwork technique where she was creating geometric shapes and grids that seemed to curve through space. I was impressed with the scale of the patchworks and the calculations of gradients and shapes, and was intrigued to hear her talk about her process. She was pursuing certain effects and experiences in her pieces that she often couldn't assess until she had finished nearly all the sewing on each piece. In passing she mentioned the large stacks of rejected, nearly finished works

5 The Swedish word for release is very closely linked to the word for birth, and the word for birth also includes a sense of something coming loose, which felt significant to me when the sculpture broke.

that she had in her studio, and I thought to myself: *I would love to do something with those.*

When we met up in her studio later that year, one piece attracted me in particular because of the colours and the asymmetric shape, and I photographed myself wearing it across my hips. This patchwork would be one of four pieces Inger let me have when we met up again in 2024.

The pieces hung on my studio wall for a long time before I dared to approach them. To turn them into garments seemed cheap in some way, like turning them from art back into mere fabric. But the techniques of dressmaking, of draping a garment are useful tools for creating volume, so I decided to dress a different kind of body. At first I attempted to build a shape out of pillow stuffing, but it turned out too soft and seemed repulsive to me, a huddled being left on my desk. I felt this weak shape would disrespect Inger's work. I wanted the body to be taller and more angular, maybe tall and big enough to incorporate several of the patchwork pieces. I wanted the inside structure to be made out of wood, but just thinking about sawing or drilling or nailing made my skin crawl. Possibly my reaction was so strong because making plans, leaving the studio, going to a hardware store would have broken the fragile flow of creativity. I decided to tie together pieces of wood I had lying around the studio, using brightly coloured nylon cord. I was building my own Frankenstein's monster, all roughly stitched together with the tangled workings clearly visible. There is a sense of freedom in imperfection.

I kept adding to the wooden "skeleton" until I could fit at least two of Inger's pieces onto it, creating some sort of bird figure. One of the fabrics was placed with the back facing out, to show Inger's numbering system and all the threads hanging off the seam allowances. I had decided that everything I added would be in strong colours, partly to contrast the subdued grey and lavender tones in the patches, and partly to give myself some courage to make a mark and break free of my respect for Inger, who used to be my professor after all. I had tentatively added stuffed yellow and orange shapes in some places but found the accidental 80's aesthetic revolting. *I have to allow myself to make ugly!* Trying to stay bold I started adding neon orange cord along some of

the lines of the patches, softening the corners and creating some movement. I liked the look of this, and the activity in itself. It became a calming task to return to every time I got stuck in my process with the other objects. The stick coming out of the top was bothering me more and more as the sculpture started to resemble a figure to me. *I might have to saw it off. I'm getting bog-body vibes, like someone being speared on a pole.* I had the saw in my hand but changed my mind at the last minute. It would close the shape, I wanted to keep it open, to open it up more! I added another stick instead so it could keep growing in all directions.

In order to solve the issue of height I decided I needed a more stable material to continue the sculpture. This led to me spending some days in the metal workshop at Konstfack, learning to cut and weld metal tubes, creating a crisscrossing metal base to echo the wooden skeleton.

Working with Inger's objects seems to have struck a cord of teenage rebellion, our previous relationship of student–professor having brought out a surprisingly punk expression in my response. To untangle myself and assert my independence I had to rebel, visually, and in order to not lose my nerve I had to invent repetitive tasks where I could enter a flow, stitch by stitch or stick by stick.

CHASING FLOW AND UNBRIDLED CREATIVITY

The term "flow" was popularised by the psychologist Mihály Csíkszentmihályi in the 1980's.[6] A state where you are fully absorbed and immersed in the task at hand. Mårten Medbo describes the repetitive and manual aspects of his ceramic practice as inducing a "druggy" state.[7] But he raises the question whether it is always good to be making without reflecting. Referring to Hannah Arendt's writings he follows the tangent all the way to the creation of the atomic bomb, the thought being that if humans follow their creativity it can lead to destructive results. Crafts or arts is generally considered positive, a benign type of creation, yet if you scratch the surface there are environmental, political,

6 Kyaga, Simon & Mattsson, Jonas, *Ekvilibrium: om sambandet mellan kreativitet och galenskap*, First edition, Natur & kultur, Stockholm, 2022, p. 31.

7 Sörmlands museum, *Hantverk, material och mening med Mårten Medbo*, Youtube, 2021, https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=j4QnQTNxrIU, 12:45, 2024-11-21.



colonial etc. problems with any material and thereby any practice. I find thoughts like this can create blocks and induce creative paralysis.

Searching for a key to unblocked creativity my thoughts go to the, somewhat problematic, "art brut", a term coined by Jean Dubuffet who considered it a form of pure art.[8] I've always been fascinated by stories about people creating beautiful and intricate art from inside mental institutions, like Adolf Wölfli (1864–1930), a self-taught artist who would create large intricate drawings that included stories and music notation as a patient at the Waldau Clinic in Bern.[9] Or the seamstress Agnes Richter (1844–1918) who was a patient at the Heidelberg Psychiatric Clinic during the 1890s and who would densely embroider her straitjacket with words and phrases, turning it into a striking work of art.[10]

Of course, these patients were by no means untroubled while working on their art. Reading about Adolf Wölfli I find that he found the work with the images very strenuous "There is so much that needs to be done. You can't imagine how one must strain one's head not to forget something. It is enough to make you mad if you weren't already".[11] In their book on the connection between creativity and madness Simon Kayla and Jonas Mattsson explore their scientific findings relating to mental health.

"It's in the vicinity of or in parts of the mental illness that creativity thrives. We have tried to illustrate this with the upside-down U curve, where the creative equilibrium is at the top. The right hand, descending part of the curve represents illness that causes great suffering for the individual."[12]

8 Rhodes, Colin, *Outsider art: art brut and its affinities*, New edition., Thames & Hudson Ltd, London, 2022, p. 14.

9 Wölfli, Adolf, *Adolf Wölfli: 1864-1930 : Moderna museet, Stockholm 29 jan-6 mars 1977,* Moderna mus., Stockholm, 1977.

10 Röske, Thomas: *Agnes Richter's jacket*, Epidemiol Psychiatr Sci, 2014 Sep;23(3), p. 227-9.

11 Wölfli, Adolf, *Adolf Wölfli: 1864-1930 : Moderna museet, Stockholm 29 jan-6 mars 1977*, Moderna mus., Stockholm, 1977, p 6, Dieter Koepplin quotes from "Ein Geisteskranker als Künstler" by Walter Morgenthaler. My Translation from the Swedish translation.

12 Kyaga, Simon & Mattsson, Jonas, *Ekvilibrium: om sambandet mellan kreativitet och galenskap*, First edition, Natur & kultur, Stockholm, 2022, p. 67, my translation.

Clearly mental illness is not something I, or anyone else, wishes for. Possibly my fascination with the "freedom" of insanity is a wish to avoid the problematic obstacles of any creative practice. I just want to get at that lovely, intoxicating flow state.

DRIPPING CLOUD – A DIALOGUE WITH AGNETA FLOCK

In November 2024 I drove to Täby Kyrkby, north of Stockholm, where the textile artist Agneta Flock lives with her husband. I had met Agneta when she held an artist's talk in an exhibition at Statens Konstråd where her "Velvet jungle" from the 1970's was on display. The piece made an impression on me through its scale, colour, tactile materiality and the sense of growing movement.

I was curious and a bit nervous to enter this home that displayed art and memories spanning a lifetime. We had coffee and talked for several hours about her long career as an artist. Agneta showed me some small wool pieces, figures and shapes, that shehad cut out for appliqué. I considered collecting these but I could sense she had an idea about what I should do with them, the outcome seemed too fixed. We talked about her 60's and 70's work and she showed me some pictures of very large scale patchwork- and appliqué pieces she had made, and I found myself wishing for something in that vein. We put on our shoes and walked through the newly fallen snow to the weaving studio in the garden. She brought out a small piece of handwoven cloth in brown, black and white goat's wool. "Maybe you could embroider something on this?" she said. I hesitated. I could sense it was still a little precious to her, even though it was only a trial piece she had woven back in 1966. I asked if she had anything else for me, and she brought out a cut-off from a weave, a leftover from when she made her latest tapestry. Relieved to see the weave already unraveling where it had been cut and the roughly tied bows at the end of the warp, I gladly accepted. This I would actually dare to do something with.

The beautiful, loosely spun wool yarn in the weave had been a gift to her in the 70's when she had exhibited one of her "Velvet jungles" in Poland. Visitors to the exhibition had ended up taking pieces from it until there was nothing left. As a repayment the polish textile artist Jolanta Owidzka gifted Agneta a large



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amount of hand-spun wool, which she is still dyeing and weaving with to this day. I was already getting entangled in the stories embedded in this dialogue.

I felt early on that I wanted to continue the warp where it had been cut off. Partly to stop the wool yarn from unraveling completely and partly to create a base for my own additions. I brought out some bags of yarn that are left-overs from my mother's and grandmother's old weaving projects. My grandmother who was a proud professional, a nurse, and the first in her family to graduate from higher education, didn't enjoy handicrafts at all, but she would occasionally start some project of needlework or other, eventually abandoning them in boredom. My mother, on the other hand, enjoyed both sewing and weaving, but being an architect and a mother of three she had little time for crafts during my childhood. However, she kept all leftover materials and has given some to me. Apparently she decided to keep a piece of a warp, less than a metre long, in brown and pink tones. Why? Clearly my hoarding tendencies are hereditary.

These yarns called to me, a warp to continue the warp, and I was happy to have created an activity that I could carry on with for a while without having to stop and analyse. I had some hours of calmly knotting before I ran out of threads and had to make a decision about the remaining length of weave. I decided the next step had to be more bold, and trying to sense my materials I picked a blue cord and started to thread it through the wool weft. Blue was really the only clue I had to work with in Agneta's piece and so it felt good to add a much brighter blue to accentuate that. I made the added cords much longer than my mother's piece of warp, continuing the piece both up- and downwards. This created a swooping curve in the weave, new directions and a possibility of movement. The loops of warp at the bottom now created a decorative fringe of bows following the curve. The piece had been opened up to many more possibilities, and so I couldn't help feeling a little exhilarated.

What to do next? I was hoping to be able to express a little bit more of myself in my additions to this object since it had been such a small sliver to start with, and I wanted to connect to the

boldness and colourfulness of Agneta's earlier works that I had found so inspiring. Puzzling over how to hang the weave, I decided to make one of my wooden shapes covered in appliqué to hang it from. I quickly sketched out shapes on some cardboard, spontaneously creating swirls and waves that grew out of the corners. It had movement, almost like a dripping cloud, and I transferred it to wood, happy to spend some time just sawing and sewing.

I then had to solve the issue of how to attach the fabric to the wood, ideally using needle and thread. Trying out some black nails I fell in love with the dotted outline they created around the fabric shapes. I worked out a way to sew into the fabric and loop around the nails, making the appliqué float on the surface. Working on the wood appliqué I considered whether it had made the hanging weave redundant. I enjoy the concept of elevating something quiet and humble by giving it a flamboyant frame, but I can also see this dialogue pointing me in a direction where I don't need an external starting point at all.

COMMUNICATING WITH OBJECTS

In these joint makings, these artistic dialogues, I have attempted to "listen" to the materials and objects I have received, acknowledging the existence of "*Thing-Power:* the curious ability of inanimate things to animate, to act, to produce effects dramatic and subtle", in the words of Jane Bennett.[13] Materials and objects that end up in my care hold a certain power over me. You might say I have a touch of hoarder syndrome. I find it psychologically and morally difficult to throw away anything potentially useful, and as a consequence I own a considerable amount of broken clothes, short pieces of string, sole buttons and screws etc.

Bennett speaks of "vital materialists" who feel they share a commonality with objects, which may induce them "to treat nonhumans—animals, plants, earth, even artefacts and commodities—more carefully, more strategically, more ecologically." The materials speak to me. Sometimes through a history that I know of, for example my mother's leftover weaving yarn or old theatre

13 Bennett, Jane. *Vibrant Matter : A Political Ecology of Things*, Duke University Press, 2010. ProQuest Ebook Central, http://ebookcentral.proquest.com/lib/konstfack/detail.action?docID=1170671. Created from konstfack on 2024-12-09 18:56:38.

garments I've found in a school attic. Sometimes it's enough that these things are there, in my house or my studio, however they ended up there, and getting rid of them would be an affront to these innocent objects. Their potential hasn't been unlocked yet! What if no-one else understands them like I do?

Kirsty Robertson writes about textile hoarding specifically and argues that "Crafting has created a socially acceptable form of hoarding, one that is both celebrated and tinged with guilt." She claims that "[b]uying yarn, or wool or textiles means purchasing both the object and also its potential to be made into something else. The stash thus has a past, present and future."[14]

LOSS AND GROWTH – A DIALOGUE WITH LEIF HOLMSTRAND

Leif Holmstrand came to Konstfack and held a talk about their art practice in October 2024. At the time I felt blocked, the baby was still stuck in the sculpture (see Birth) and I felt paralysed in my own practice. They gave a glimpse into a world where objects fused, grew into clusters, where Leif and these morphed object-beings got overgrown, dressed in crochet and were activated in movement, poetry and song. Maybe this is the way to truly activate and honor a discarded object, to turn it into a work of art as a sendoff before allowing it to move on to "the other side". I was blown away.

I felt a kinship with what I was trying to explore in my own practice. Would it be possible for me to work bigger and dirtier, and would I want to? Leif agreed to meet up with me a couple of months later at Iaspis in Stockholm, where they had recently had a studio residency. Leif told me they had left behind some "embarrassing failures" there that I could have.

The discarded art-pieces I was allowed to take with me after our meeting were rather large and, realising I had forgotten to bring any kind of bag, Leif very kindly allowed me to have their laundry bag, messing up the packing for their homeward journey. Leif told me this piece had been used once as a prop in one of their

14 Robertson, Kirsty, *Secret stash: Textiles, hoarding, collecting, accumulation and craft* in Black, Anthea & Burisch, Nicole, *The new politics of the handmade*, first edition, London: Bloomsbury Visual Arts, 2021, 188.

performances. There they would carry around the large crocheted pole, dragging the cardboard box, also enclosed in crocheted jute, and trailing the bows of painted shibori fabrics and bin bags along with it.

Hanging Leif's piece in my studio I felt exhilarated and inspired, but also quite overwhelmed. This was by now a recognisable pattern after meeting with a collaborator. Nearly a month after our meeting I was finally ready to interact with Leif's work. The first thing I did was to remove the bin bag and the cardboard box covered in black tape and elastic. I had had that urge already from the start, but I had hesitated. It felt like I was tidying up their art. But still, there was a closedness there that had to go. I unraveled the long crocheted rope and hung the pole as high as I could.

Digging around for materials to add to it I found my own shibori trials, kept from my university days, they seemed a natural way to connect myself to the work. However, other old projects were also unearthed in the process, embarrassing failures of my own, and I begun to stuff them into the empty net that had held the box, creating a colourful growth of rejections. I found more and more shibori samples and decided to just stitch them together and hang them from the pole. I had also hung a red branch I had found and some of my drawings of wilted plants. Just trying to add things that speak to me and of me.

The red branch slowly lost its bright colour. I started dragging home recently cut branches I found around my neighbourhood. There was a thought that if I could add more branches, maybe paint them in even brighter colours I would be able to direct attention to the magic I had experienced in that first little twig. The branches began piling up in my studio, a constant presence in the corner of my eye. One particular pine branch was evoking all kinds of feelings. It was very brittle and little twigs kept falling off. Nearly all the needles were gone and the vulnerability of it made me start painting a series of what I came to see as portraits. I didn't intend to use them at first, it was simply an inescapable urge. I put the twig portraits away and started painting the big branch in bright colours with an aim to add it to the hanging installation.

I struggled back and forth with the piece, moved it to Konstfack and back to my studio. My shibori fabrics eventually ended up inside the growth of rejections and the painted branch took over, even though it kept breaking every time I moved it. I collected all the twigs and needles and kept them, finally hanging them like beads on strings from the crocheted pole. The more I thought about it the twig portraits seemed to me the final work. Had I simply used Leifs piece as a springboard to create something completely different, had it in fact been burned in the process, like a catalyst? It wasn't until the dialogue work hung in the exhibition space at Konstfack that I realised it could all exist together.

Leif was still present and recognisable in the work, but I had inserted myself into his net, added my own story and then continued on to shine my light on the impermanence of everything. Both of us speaking of sadness and loss.

HEALING OR DESTRUCTION

I let collected abandoned objects speak to me and I lean into my instincts of taking care of the misunderstood and the discarded. Am I stuck in a female gender role of caretaking and needlework that I actually should break out of? Yet the sense of defiance in caring slowly for something that other people find useless seems important to me and, in a hyper-capitalist society, almost in itself destructive. Like sabotaging the big wheels of commerce, by not subscribing to norms of productivity, commercialism, mastery, or even beauty.

I believe my practice could align with amateurism in the field of crafts, and what Glenn Adamson calls the typical Feminist account of craft "which stresses its '[association] with trivialised and degraded categories of 'women's work' outside of the fine arts'".[15] I want to believe that you don't have to be "good" to have value. Aiming to master a technique or a material could even stifle what you are trying to express. As Julietta Singh puts it: "as a pursuit, mastery invariably and relentlessly reaches toward the indiscriminate control over something *objectified* – whether it be external or internal to oneself. In so doing, mastery requires a rupturing of the object being mastered, because to be mastered

15 Adamson, Glenn, *Thinking through craft*, second edition, London: Bloomsbury Visual Arts, 2018, 151, quote: Raven, Arlene, *Blood sisters: Feminist Art and Criticism* in Lee, Lydia, et.al., *Division of Labor: "Women's Work" in Contemporary Art*, New York: Bronx Museum of Art, 1995, 47.



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means being weakened to a point of fracture."[16] Although she speaks of mastery in a colonial sense she claims that it can also be applied to practices that are generally seen as "harmless, worthwhile, even virtuous"– such as crafts. Personally I balk at technical expertise and perfect finish in my practice because I fear I would internalise external expectations and thereby put hurdles between myself and my making – and I don't believe in a right and a wrong way of doing almost anything in the context of art. It's all rules set up by humans, not nature given. I'm speaking here of material and technical solutions, not larger environmental or humanist issues.

Doing needlework that doesn't aim to be perfect is also a way of distancing myself from the traditional aspects of embroidery or textile crafts, an instinct that I suspect isn't entirely noble. It might quite possibly be a way to get to associate myself with "the cool kids", the real artists. (The male artists?) As Roszika Parker writes "When women paint, their work is categorised as homogeneously feminine – but it is acknowledged to be art. When women embroider, it is seen not as art, but entirely as the expression of femininity. And crucially it is categorised as craft."[17] She claims that "rather than acknowledging that needlework and painting are different but equal arts, embroidery and crafts associated with 'the second sex' or the working class are accorded lesser artistic value." Crafts and textile based practices have gained higher status since she wrote her text, but wonder how far we have really come. In my own practice I often find that I consider my work too small, meek or quiet, and I constantly work against that through choices of colours, materials and scale. Possibly a mere personal struggle, but as second wave feminists put it "the personal is political".[18]

Why do I think small is bad and big is automatically better?

16 Singh, Julietta. *Unthinking Mastery : Dehumanism and Decolonial Entanglements*, Duke University Press, 2017, p. 15, ProQuest Ebook Central, http://ebookcentral.proquest.com/lib/konstfack/detail.action?docID=5173432. Created from konstfack on 2024-12-09 18:57:58.

17 Parker, Rozsika, *The Subversive Stitch: Embroidery and the Making of the Feminine*, London: The Women's Press Ltd, 1996, p. 4.

18 Although the origin of the phrase "the personal is political" is uncertain, it became popular following the publication in 1970 of an essay of the same name by American feminist Carol Hanisch, who argued that many personal experiences (particularly those of women) can be traced to one's location within a system of power relationships." https://www.britannica.com/topic/the-personal-is-political, 2025-02-18.

PAPER LEAF – A DIALOGUE WITH JOHANNES HELDÉN

I have known Johannes for a long time and asking him to join my project was a spur of the moment idea. His art includes painting, poetry, music, digital work and sculpture – but not textile art. There is always a tactile aspect to his works, even the digital ones, but I wasn't sure how our practices would connect.

Johannes was the last artist I met up with to receive a work. We had a long talk about the different aspects of our creative processes, and I was particularly taken by his belief that art can truly contain some sort of magic. He said this was something he had experienced mainly through other peoples work, but the possibility of magic was part of the reason he could allow his work to follow its own path. The work I got to take home was a large digital printout of a leaf with writing on it. The paper had been cut to follow the shape of the leaf. It was rolled up and creased. Johannes thought that the reason he had rejected it might have been the scale of it, or the medium through which it was made. It wasn't clear what it was, but something wasn't right, or good enough.

I brought it to my studio and let it rest until I felt ready to engage with it. The leaf sat on my wall for weeks before I realised it was legible. I had made out some words before but not seen the full story. The poem was very powerful, especially since I was slow to decipher it and the subject of life and death, growth and decay hit me gradually. As of now I still don't know what my answer will be.

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INSIGHTS FROM THE MAKING

When I started these collaborations I had an idea that my work would be an act of caretaking. In the end it turned out to be a process that was less about healing and more about growing. My answers to what I have received taking the shape of a counter argument or an open question.

The precision and meticulousness of Inger's work was contrasted by course stitching and messy carpentry. The frenzy and clutter of Leif's work was answered with serene studies of individual found twigs. The anonymous shape and colour of Klara's sculpture was met with stark colours and an attempt to assert personality. The mild, plant-dyed tones and the soft shapelessness of Agneta's weave was juxtaposed with playful shapes, fixed to a hard surface. In the course exhibition I also included Johannes' leaf, still rolled up, tied together with bright nylon cords. Somehow the yarns, the cords, the threads connected all the works and created a wider conversation between the different objects. A conversation that may well continue into the future.

This, in a way, has been an exploration of different artists' voices, in an attempt to find my own.

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LISA SANDER THREADS OF THOUGHT AND MAKING UNTANGLING THE REJECTED, GETTING ENTANGLED IN THE PROCESS

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SOMPASENVUOMA QUEERNESS

THE SPACE, THE MATERIALS, THE CRAFT

IDA ISAK WESTERBERG

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The mire[1] might seem scary and unpredictable for those who are strangers to it. When you are familiar with it and know where to go and which tussocks that carries you the mire becomes a safe space where you can hide and be embraced. For whom where queer is a concept they do not understand, our norm breaking behaviors can seem scary and uncomfortable. Their first instinct might be to prohibit behaviors because it is easier with distance. But those who are brave enough to dip their toes in uncharted waters will soon understand that it is a space all about inclusion and solidarity. Once you are in a queer space, you cannot feel safer. This text is about these spaces, that might be scary when you do not know them but are the most secure, kind spaces when you do.

> When we call a place by name it is transformed from wilderness to homeland. I imagined that this beloved place knew my true name as well, even when I myself did not.[2]

Queer people have always lived in Torne valley. If you have been taught to feel shame about your mother tongue, it must be even harder to be proud of a sexuality or gender that does not align with the majority. Especially in an area that historically has been seen as stereotypical male, where you need to be strong and provide for your family during harsh conditions. For men, the worst you could be was *knapsu*, which has been a very condescending word for a feminine man. To add to that there is *laestadianism*, a strict conservative religious movement that to this day is influential in Torne valley. To break the norms is, and has been, nearly impossible and that's why a lot of queer people move to bigger cities to be able to be themselves and to be surrounded by a community. With more representation it's easier to live in one place. In recent years we are a few artists that are working with queer and tornedalian thematics, making queer lives of Torne valley more visible.[3] I want to contribute with the tool I know best, weaving, and I want to do it in the queerest, tornedalian place I know – the mire. This is where Sompasenvuoma enters the story.

1 Mires are landscapes with both bog and marsh qualities, very common in the north of Sweden.

2 Wall Kimmerer, *Braiding Sweetgrass,* p. 34.

3 See the dancers Eva Svaneblom and Marcus Baldemar, the artists Karin Keisu and Josse Thuresson and the drag artist Miss Knapsu.

THE SPACE

In Meänkieli, *vuoma* is the word for a big open mire without trees. That gives us a picture of a landscape long before our time. Today the mire Sompasenvuoma looks nothing like this description, it is quite insignificant with small trees dispersed throughout. Today you would maybe call them a *jänkkä* or a *rämeä*. There are a lot of different words for wetlands in Meänkieli and Finnish.[4]

In 2019 I started to explore wetlands[5] and through that, I found Sompasenvuoma. Sompasenvuoma is a mire that is located 20 kilometers north of Övertorneå in the forest that my parents have taken over after my grandparents. I felt excited and embraced when I started to explore this space, and I could not understand why I felt so validated. It was as if my queer self and my tornedalian identity for the first time merged. Since then, me and this mire have been collaborating, and a relationship has evolved. I want to find a way to describe how the mire can be seen as a queer space in places where queer spaces are hard to find. What can queer mires contribute to a society where the norms are quite narrow?

WETLANDS BEYOND THE BINARY

Through reading, Sompasenvuoma and I travel to wetlands around the world. First, we travel to the peatlands in Patagonia through Turba-Tol Hol Hol, the publication from the Chilean pavilion at the Venice biennale 2022.[6] It's a long journey through continents and time zones. Carla Macchiavello Cornejo and Camila Marambio, two of the curators and the editors of the text, writes in the introduction that the project highlights the indigenous and extinct Selk'nam people through working with peatlands. We get to know about their lost language that is being rediscovered, and Sompasenvuoma finds similarities with their own space. When moving across the mire in earlier times, the people spoke the same language as the land. Today the language is something totally different and the mire struggles to

4 When getting to know words in meänkieli, I've taken help from the Swedish-meänkieli dictionary at https://xn--sprk-soa.isof.se/me%C3%A4nkieli/

5 Together with Anna Classon as a part of Galleri Syster's project SamArtBete: https://idaisak.se/?p=303

6 Carla Macchiavello Cornejo and Camila Marambio, *Turba Tol-Hol Hol*, p. 17.

understand.[7] CM2 write that working with the peatlands is a "journey to the heart of the marginalized" and that they want "to interweave worlds and bring fragments together, to gather strengths and leave behind the binary, to add (like streams to a river) to the biodiversity of this planet Earth."[8] If they could unleash all the stories that are conserved in the peat and make them come to light at the Venice biennale, Sompasenvuoma and I can do our best as well.

The nomadic research collective Ensayos,[9] which where a big part of the exhibition Turba-Tol Hol Hol, is participating in the exhibition *Down in the bog,* first in Tallin and afterwards in Tromsø. Curator Karolin Tampere shows us part of their work in a project that highlights the properties of the peatlands when dealing with climate change. In a publication for the exhibitions Tampere writes:

> Peatlands blur binaries. They are liquid and solid, a cooperative ecosystem consisting of minerals, nutrients, plants, bacteria and so much more. A living memory-medium where visible and invisible stories are stored over thousands of years. A hybrid archive considered to be a portal between the worlds of the living and the non-living. [10]

We continue our journey and travel to the Lachlan Swamps in Sydney, wetlands that are used for fucking. In the article "Queering the swamp" Taylor Coyne writes about a paperbark swamp that is a well-known cruising spot for men that have sex with men. Coyne tells us that fluid spaces "connect queer biologies and queer ecologies with queer practices of fucking in the bushes" and that "the margins are ... safe places – places of liberation and pleasure."[11] Sompasenvuoma thinks about the possibilities of inviting to activities like this but has concerns since they already have guests during the warm months. Mosquitos, blackflies and

7 Sompasenvuoma is located in a Meänkieli and Sami speaking area. Nowadays the majority speaks Swedish. Karin Keisu writes about this subject in her MFA essay *Becoming Tornedalian*.

8 Carla Macchiavello Cornejo and Camila Marambio, *Turba Tol-Hol Hol*, p17.

9 Tampere, *Down in the bog - Sporulation*, p. 43.

10 Tampere, *Down in the bog - Sporulation*, p. 9.

11 Coyne, Queering the Swamp.

horseflies are the main tourists and would love a plus size meal of blood, but the humans would be horrified. Maybe it's best to focus on the wood grouse play and the moose rut after all.

In the same way that queers have always adjusted in urban settings that are not structured for us[12], plants and animals have adjusted to the mire's harsh conditions of almost no nutrition. Before going home to Torne Valley, we make a stop in Marksjön where Bronwyn Bailey-Charteris makes a portrait of Signe Johannessen and her collaboration with the swamp mentioned above, Marksjön. Bailey-Charteris refers to the carnivorous plant, the sundew, and points out how the sundew is queering categories[13] by eating animals instead of being eaten. Vranken, Ardalani and Brebenel have also made this observation and write that swamps "offer space for queerness. For beings that fall in between categories".[14]

In our travels, we meet people that are invested in what the wetlands have to offer and in every place we are embraced by moist, wet peat. In Torne Valley the mires are known for cloudberry picking, moose hunting and haymaking, activities that are culturally important for Tornedalians. After reading about all the characteristics and use of wetlands around the world, I am even more convinced that the mires in Torne valley can offer more nuance to the way we view Tornedalian life. The mire is non-binary; neither firm ground nor lakes you can swim in. It's everything and nothing at the same time but most of all, it is its own and it's unique to everything around it with its own ground and its own plants and its own demands in the place it occupies.

I want to put the queerness of the mire Sompasenvuoma into the tradition of tornedalian weaving patterns. Inspired by Doris Wiklunds book "Gamla vävnader från Norrbotten",[15] I want to create a Sompasendräll that only becomes visible in the fabric through Sompasenvuoma's own materials.

12 Mortimer Sandilands and Erickson, *Queer Ecologies*, p. 15.

13 Bailey-Charteris, *Sucked in: Erotics of the svamp,* p. 36.

14 Vranken, Ardalani, Brebenel, *Thinking-with the swamp*, A text written for an event in Brussels called The Swamp Gathering.

15 Wiklund, *Gamla vävnader från Norrbotten*, p. 11.

THE MATERIALS

When I've been collaborating with Sompasenvuoma earlier, I have brought materials to be manipulated by the space, yarn has been solar dyed with plants and water from the mire and woven pieces have been dug down in the peat. This time I explore what happens with the woven piece if Sompasenvuoma is a part of the weaving process as well. Through offering different materials as weft, stories about this queer space can be told when woven into a cloth. Can we, through this, "interweave worlds and bring fragments together, to gather strengths and leave behind the binary" as expressed by Macchiavello Cornejo and Marambio?[16]

ROOTS

I want to work with roots. The roots have their own sculpting properties, and if you use them as weft the fabric will follow the root's directions. The roots' living conditions in the peat has given the roots their shapes and makes the texture of the fabric. They tell the story about what is happening under the ground.

It is summer and I am going to the mire to collect some roots, following directions from Gunilla Axelsson and Gunnel Eriksson's book "Första Rotboken med extra allt". The best time for taking roots is in the spring when the sap in the birch is high, then the bark on the roots will let go more easily and the roots will be easier to work with.[17] In the instructions it says to find a birch without any other trees or plants around it, but Sompasenvuoma is filled with different kinds of plants and root systems. It is very hard to find roots and when I find them, I don't know which roots it is.

When I collect materials on Sompasenvuoma I ask the environment for permission to gather[18] and by making it difficult for me, Sompasenvuoma tells me that I should leave the roots alone until I know what I am doing. I go home with a very small amount and realize that if I want to use them in this project, I also need to find some other materials to work with because the roots I have won't

16 Macchiavello Cornejo and Marambio, *Turba Tol-Hol Hol*, p. 17.

17 Axelsson and Eriksson, *Första Rotboken med extra allt*, p. 20.

18 Wall Kimmerer, *Braiding Sweetgrass*, p. 183.







Images from top to bottom:
Gathering roots
Gathering sphagnum
Gathering birch bark
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be enough. The following days I peel the bark off the roots and put them to dry before storing them waiting for the next move.

SPHAGNUM

The sphagnum collects information from my footsteps, my coffee breaks, my hair and skin falling off, fibers from my clothes and woven pieces. It collects my tears and my bodily fluids and brings them into its decaying process and with time it will be stored further and further down the peat.

> The sphagnum is the living membrane stretched between two shores, creating a meeting place for earth and sky, embracing the water within.[19]

In September I am showing Sompasenvuoma to a friend and colleague, we sit down on a tussock and drink coffee, and I tell her about my work. I then want to show her the overgrown ditch that runs through the bog. In the late 19th century, people began to dig ditches to drain the land and turn it into agricultural and forestry land and peat extraction. People received compensation from the state until the 1990s to dig their land to increase production capacity, but in many cases the result was the opposite.[20]

The ditch has now been taken over by bright green sphagnum, I still don't know which kind. When showing my friend the ditch, Sompasenvuoma tells me to put my hand around the sphagnum and pull it up. With me I get this string of moss that is almost 50 centimeters long. In the top it's bright green, it fades into white and then the acids in the water have made the end a bit brownish. The fishy smell is significant. "I got plenty of this", Sompasenvuoma tells me, "maybe it's something for your studies."

I grab a big handful and take it home with me. What happens if I use the sphagnum as weft in the overshot? What happens with the pattern when the sphagnum is making it? I lay the sphagnum at a table in my dyeing studio where it gets to dry and wait.

19 Wall Kimmerer, *Gathering Moss*, p. 118.

20 Länsstyrelsen i Norrbotten län, *Våtmarker i Norrbotten*, p. 32.

BIRCH BARK

There are many different layers in the bark that embrace and protect the birch from outer conditions.[21] Each layer is thin and flexible and together they become strong. In the bark there is a kind of glue, and if you use hot water or steam you can activate that glue and use it to sculpt the surface. To activate it also makes the bark stronger. According to Eva Nilsson, one of the birch bark writers, some say that the winter birch bark is more beautiful, stronger and more durable than if you take it when the birch is full of sap. If you want to harvest birch bark during winter, you need to wait for the days with above zero degrees celcius after a cold period.[22]

During Christmas it is around -17 degrees celsius and a few days later the temperature rises making it +5. Any other winter I would be disappointed because plus degrees are only trouble this time of year but now I get the opportunity to gather some birch bark on the mire.

In the middle of Sompasenvuoma there are small birches, and I make my first attempt at one of them. When putting the knife in the bark it feels almost like a sponge underneath. I make a cut in the bark and when I pull it off, I realize that it had already let go of the trunk. On the inside of the bark there is a black surface. I collect that piece of bark but realize that this tree has already started its decaying process and maybe I should just let it be.

Suddenly I see two perfect looking birches standing at the edge of the mire. They are shouting for me to come and I walk there in the fastest pace possible through all the tussocks under two decimeters of snow. After talking to the birch for a while I know where it wants me to put the knife. The bark lets go but my knife is quite big and I don't get the connection to the tree that I need. The birch only releases the bark in strings, which is ok since it is going to be turned into weft later anyway. When collecting these birch bark strings I find a trace of chaga that was about to break out. There are some of it on the collected strings as well – maybe

21 Dahlqvist, *Näver*, p. 19.

22 Nilsson, *Av Näver Och Rot*, p. 18.

it charges the weaving with even more power? On my way back I pass one older birch where the bark has already started to let go of the outer layer. I take it as a sign that it wants me to collect that as well before going home.

WOOL

The wool is secondary to the materials collected from the mire which is why I am going to use yarn that I already have from earlier projects. In the first samples I use a yarn that is, among other things, used for scarf weaving. In the later pieces I use a thicker one to see what happens with the pattern with less contrast in size between the collected materials and the yarn. The woolen yarn is important for creating a balanced plain weave as a base. It is only there so the pattern can be visible through the materials.

THE CRAFT

The Kven artist Åsne Kummeneje Mellem is working with *käsityö* which means craft and is the same word in Kven and in Meänkieli. She is talking about the generational gaps in knowledge that has been created because of the Norwegianization and she is trying to take back the knowledge through making with materials that have been used in Kven areas.[23] We participated at the same exhibition in Rovaniemi 2021[24], and it was amazing to find an artist that works with the same methods as me, just on the Norwegian side of the border instead of the Swedish one where I'm located. She is talking about kven crafts as something to investigate and to use *käsityö* to inspire others to also work within these crafts. I find it remarkable that even though both of us have lost knowledge and are looking for it through our craft, we find the same methods to work with – recognizing it as kven and tornedalian craft.

23 Maija Liisa Björklund, *In Search of Käsityö*.

24 Young Arctic Artists, *Kamppailu /Fight*.

CREATING A SOMPASENDRÄLL – MAKING A PATTERN

Doris Wiklunds has gathered woven textiles from all around Norrbotten, creating an archive for the weaving history up north. She observes that a lot of the textiles are woven in monks' belt or in overshot. A lot of them have a deep yellow in the plain weave while the weft that overshoots have a contrasting color.[25] When I dye yarn with plants from Sompasenvuoma, the most common color I get is yellow. Labrador tea gives a shade that is almost golden and there is a lot of labrador tea around the mire. Even during the autumn, when the colder degrees hit, it's still possible to harvest and dye with the plant. Heather has a warmer tone than labrador tea and is also collectable all year round. The plain weave might then be woven with woolen warp and weft, dyed with labrador tea and heather.

In Norrbotten there are some famous weaving patterns that received their names from the village where the inventor of the pattern grew up: *Kukkoladräll, Jukkasjärvidräll* and *Puoltsarosen*. All of them are different overshot patterns. I want to create a pattern in the same tradition for Sompasenvuoma and the area around it. Can I make an overshot pattern that symbolizes the essence of the mire?

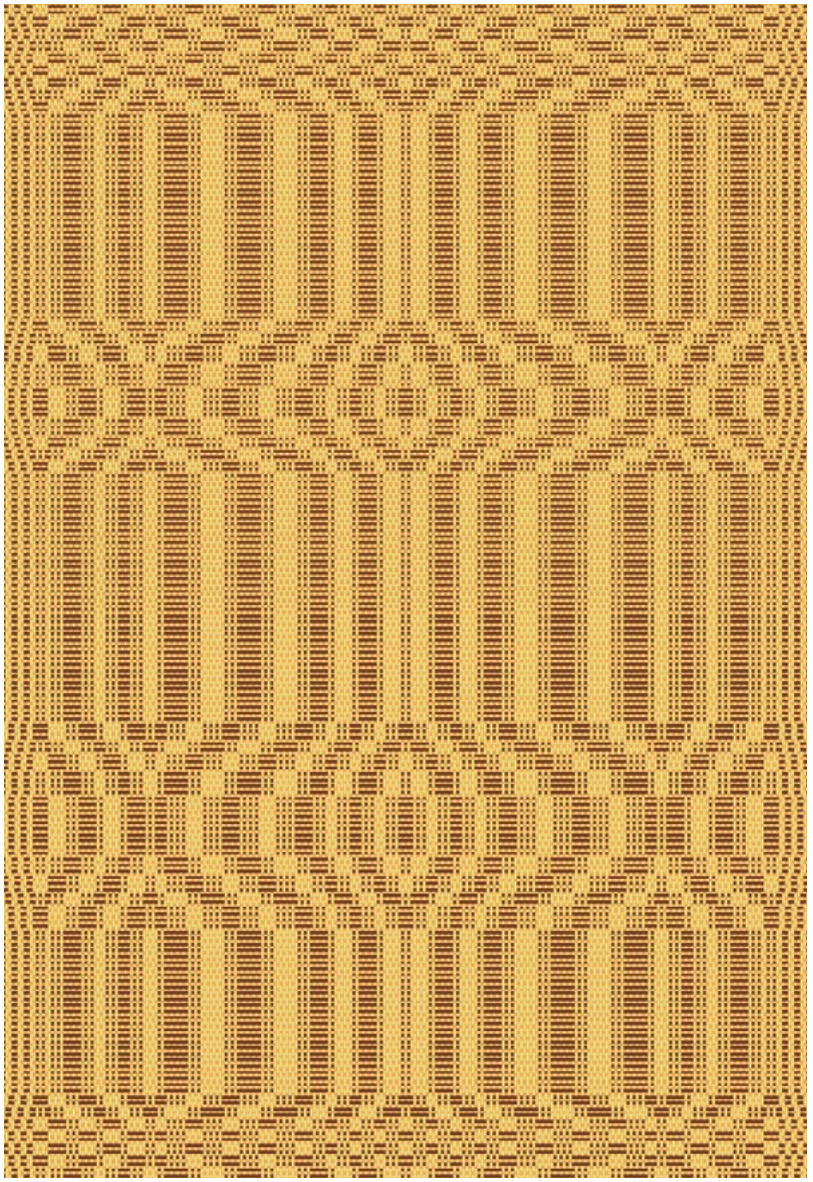
When making the pattern I start to think about this old tree that used to stand as an entrance to Sompasenvuoma in a space that was really dry. How could you find a space so dry just next to a wet mire? In this space this old, dead tree stood with its arms to each side, and I felt like it did something magical with the space. I wanted this tree in an exhibition but was not sure if that was ok with the forest. During the summer I saw how the woodpecker, by putting cones in the trunk and eating from it, was slowly destroying the tree. I thought that if I took the tree, at least it wouldn't decay. It would still exist, although outside of its environment. The tree followed me around to maybe four exhibitions before it became too fragile to drive around with and since then I've been wanting to celebrate it in my weaving. And when better than when it's time to make a *Sompasendräll*?

25 Wiklund, *Gamla vävnader från Norrbotten*, p. 11.

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The tree © Ida Isak Westerberg



The Sompasendräll pattern © Ida Isak Westerberg

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I think about the tree trunk and the holes where the woodpecker put the cones and make a first draft to see how it looks in a woven overshot structure. The overshot turns out very uneven and it takes me more than ten different sketches in Weavepoint[26] to find the one I want to continue with. My idea is to offer two alternatives, the first is to weave the tree trunk following the pattern, the other one is to break the pattern in an uneven rhythm. The pattern is there as a possibility, but you can also just queer it out.

WEAVING WITH ROOTS

Since the supply of roots is small, I decide to make a maximum of two samples with the material. I separate the roots into two piles and then I pour hot water over one of them and wait for an hour before I start to weave. If the roots are dry, they easily break. Hot water makes the process of softening them up easier.[27]

The first sample I make is in a classical daldräll style, putting one wool weft between each overshot. The look of the sample is very stripy. Every root's color is so different from the one next to it that you only can see the stripes and not the weaving pattern. The roots are too close to each other, it seems that they do not have the space to move the way they want to. In the second sample I am choosing to do four rows of plain weave between each overshot. The daldräll pattern looks abstract when you are close but from a distance you see it clearly. I get the impression that each root gets more visible when they are not packed close together.

WEAVING WITH SPHAGNUM

I bring the dry sphagnum to the weaving studio, ready to weave with it. The warp is narrower than the sphagnum is long so I decide to let the strands of sphagnum meet each other in the shed, letting them move from one overshot shed to the next. The gradient in the sphagnum isn't that visible with this technique, but more of the material can fit within the warp.

26 Weavepoint is a computer programme that helps you create different weaving patterns.

27 Eriksson and Axelsson, 2024, p. 24.

I weave one sample with the dry sphagnum and immediately small leaves of it starts to drop. I realize that this won't be durable at all. For the second sample I put the sphagnum in a wet a towel to make it damp, since that is its natural state. The fishy smell that I got from them in the mire is back. Weaving gets much easier this time, and the leaves stay on. I understand that they will start to fall off when it is dry. I leave the first sample untreated but I spray flaxseed glue all over the second one.

Even though I realize that sphagnum weaving is not a hit, I do two more tests with one strand of sphagnum as weft in each shed, not overlapping. In these samples you can see the gradient from green to brown and follow the decaying process from the oldest parts to the fresh ones. When the samples are off the loom I dip them in a mix of water and fish glue. It makes them hard but maybe even more fragile than before, breaking just by touching them. All of these samples need framing to be able to travel and to be shown. Otherwise, all the leaves will have fallen off before anyone sees them. They are so fragile with or without treatment. This material does not want to be used in this way, but it was worth trying it out. I don't recommend sphagnum weaving to anyone, since the sphagnum prefers to stay in the ditch.

WEAVING WITH BIRCH BARK

It's hard peeling of one layer from the next, the fibers break and my thumbs hurt. Eventually I try laying the birch bark between two layers of wet towels for the night. The next day, the birch bark is more collaborative and starts to release from its different layers, sometimes it's just one, sometimes two and sometimes more. I try to make them as thin as possible, but some layers are almost impossible to separate. Instead of me deciding how the layers should look, it is as if the birch bark is showing me how it wants. I get the feeling that the birch bark is deciding, and I just follow its instructions. Peeling the layers apart and putting them in the weft as strips creates a new surface that is soft and strong at the same time, like leather almost. Leather and skin. While weaving I insert the strips within the warp, between each wool thread. Sometimes they don't cover the whole width and then the next layer fills the space that the former left behind. In this way every stripe is connected to the last one and my eyes interpret each

weft's move as I go, without having decided it beforehand. It makes the weaving organic and surprising and intuitive. If the sphagnum really did not want to be woven with, the birch bark is happy to join, but on its own terms.

When the samples in Sompasendräll has been made, I can't help but dress the loom with one more warp. It's a thin one, solved in plain weave. I use the bark pieces that were too short for the other samples, and I tie them in the warp threads with rya knots. I can't help myself; I have to make a birch bark rya. Rya is my absolute favorite of all the weaving techniques. It's unruly, messy, there's nothing straight about it at all. As treatment, I steam one sample and I dip another one in hot water, shaping it under the surface and then laying it on a table to dry on in the same shape. When steaming, hot dampness made the birch bark move, creating its own shapes. I like how the material decides by itself, instead of me steering it.

INTERWOVEN CONNECTIONS

It's impossible to focus only on queerness, separating it from other minority questions. The oppressions are intertwined and that makes this text, and my work, move between marginalized questions. Everything is connected, embodied within the space, and within me.

There is a similarity between Tornedalians and queers – we adapt to harsh conditions just like the plants do on the mire. We become something else because we must deal with difficult conditions. When reading the books about roots and birch bark, something that I noticed is that the writers tell the reader to choose the best parts of the materials, the parts that are smooth and have as few imperfections as possible. And of course, if you are going to make a brooch or a basket you need some flow in the making. But for me, and for this weaving process, the imperfections have been welcomed because they help me to tell the story of the place. If everything was just smooth and perfect, it would not reflect Sompasenvuoma as a space or queer experiences.







Images from top to bottom:
Sample 1 (roots)
Sample 5 (sphagnum)
Sample 8 (birch bark)

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All the gathered materials from the mire demand to be used in their natural state, wet and moist. That makes me think about what Coyne wrote, that "the margins are ... safe places – places of liberation and pleasure".[28] Sompasenvuoma represents that margin for me, it is a place of liberation and pleasure, it is a space where I don't need to adapt because all parts of me can flourish at the same time. I hope that the woven textiles made within this context can be a reminder that these spaces exist out there for all of us – we can all be embraced by wet, moist peat.

28 Coyne, *Queering the Swamp*.







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